

THE PIET BUYS FILES

THE UNNUMBERED

book one



ANDRIES J. GREYLING

The Unnumbered

A Piet Buys Novel · Book One

They were never reported. They were never counted.

Andries J. Greyling

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This is a work of fiction. **Pieter Buys, Charmaine Adonis, and every other named character in this book are invented, and so is the man they hunt.** No real offender appears in these pages under any name, and no real victim's death is dramatised, renamed, or re-staged. Where a real case supplied a *mechanism* — how a man persuaded a woman into a vehicle, why no one looked for her afterwards — the mechanism is used and everything around it is invented. The real cases are named honestly in the afterword, where they belong.

The country these characters move through is not invented. The figures quoted in this book are real, sourced, and current at the time of writing; where a number could not be sourced, no number is given. That restraint is the character Elsie Mtimkulu's, and it is also the author's.

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Per Ardua ad Magnum.

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An Open Draft — Please Read This First

The Unnumbered is being published here as an **open, unfinished draft**, on purpose.

What you have: Movements One and Two — sixteen chapters of a planned thirty-two. The book stops on a road going north, in the middle of its own second act. It does not resolve. Nobody is caught in these pages, and the count is not final, and that is not a cliffhanger — it is simply where the drafting has got to.

What this book is. It borrows one thing from Sherlock Holmes and throws out everything else. It keeps the observation engine and the two-hander — one who sees, one who tells. It discards London, the canon, the names, the violin, the criminal mastermind, and above all it discards the genre's favourite lie: the brilliant detective whose brilliance costs him nothing.

Pieter Buys is autistic. He was diagnosed at thirty-seven, by a psychologist he had gone to see about something else. He does not deduce; he *cannot stop noticing*, and he cannot leave a noticed thing alone, and that is one faculty and not two. It solves murders. It also means a mortuary is easier than a shopping centre, and that after a day of being legible to strangers he cannot produce a sentence for three hours. There is no scene in this book where the gift appears without the bill attached, and there is no scene where he is cured, softened, or explained.

The genre has a great many autistic detectives in it, written almost entirely by people who are not autistic. This one is not.

The other thing this book will not do. Its murderer is a man with a bakkie and a labour broker's clipboard. He gets no chapters of his own, no philosophy, no memorable speech, and no scene in which he tells anyone they are alike. He is caught, eventually, by bookkeeping. The antagonist of this series is not a man at all: it is the arithmetic of who gets looked for in a country where safety is a product sold on subscription to whoever can afford it.

A word about what is in it. This is a novel about murdered women. The camera stays on the living. There is no scene from a victim's point of view and no account of anyone's final moments, and there never will be. A grieving mother's kitchen gets more pages than any crime scene, and that is the whole argument, made in the only way a novel can make it.

What is still owed before this is a finished book: the second half; a sensitivity read by an autistic reader; a Cape Flats reader on Charmaine Adonis's voice and register; and the remaining verification listed at the end of the afterword. If you are one of those readers and you want the job, the door is open.

Read it as what it is: a book being built in the open, by someone who would rather be corrected early than praised late.

Movement One — Gone for Work

Chapter 1

The gate had a sticker on it that said four minutes, which was a lie, but it was a lie the people behind the gate had agreed to pay for, and that made it a service.

I pressed the buzzer twice. Piet stood a little back from the intercom with his hands at his sides, already tired, and it was ten past eight in the morning.

“Four minutes,” I said.

“From the depot on the R44 it is eleven,” he said. “In season, with the tour buses, seventeen.”

“Don’t tell them that.”

“I am going to tell them that. It is on page two.”

The estate ran up the slope behind the gate in long green corduroy, and at the top of it there was a house with a lot of glass in it, and in the house there was a man called Dirk who had lost about nine hundred thousand rand of stock over fourteen months and wanted somebody to say the word *syndicate* to him so he could stop thinking about the people who worked for him.

Piet was not going to say syndicate. I already knew that. I had read the file in the car and Piet had read it in eleven minutes on Sunday and then not slept, and there is a particular flatness he gets around the mouth on a Monday after a Sunday like that, and I can see it now from across a room.

He put his jacket on in the driveway. That is the part people never notice, and it is the part I notice most. He does it the way a diver checks a tank.

Dirk had the meeting in the tasting room because the tasting room was the nicest space he owned, and he did not understand that it was the worst possible room for what he was buying. Skylights. Concrete floor. A fridge with a compressor that came on every ninety seconds. Nine people, three of them there for no reason at all except that they had heard there would be a consultant.

Piet sat where he always sits, which is the seat that faces the door with its back to the window, and he took out one pen and set it exactly parallel to the edge of the table.

Dirk talked for eighteen minutes. He said *syndicate* four times. He said *organised* twice. He said “you hear these things about the labour” once, and did not look at the two people from his own packhouse who were sitting at the end of the table, and they did not look at him either, and I watched them not look at each other and thought, *ja, there it is, there’s your fourteen months*.

Then Dirk said, “So. Where do we start.”

And Piet said, “You have a man who works Tuesdays.”

The fridge came on.

“Sorry?”

“Your losses are dated in the stock system. Fourteen months, thirty-one events. Twenty-six of them are recorded on a Wednesday morning. That is not when the stock left. That is when the count is done.” He had not opened the file. It was still in front of me, closed. “Your count is Wednesday at seven. Your delivery window is Tuesday afternoon. Your night shift ends at six. So it left on the Tuesday, and it left through the loading door, and it left with paperwork, because there is no forced entry in fourteen months and your camera on that door has been out since the year before last and it is still out, which means nobody has asked.”

“We had a quote for the camera—”

“You have a security contract that bills you for a camera you do not have. That is on page four.” Piet moved the pen a centimetre. “Twenty-six Tuesdays. Your casual roster changes every week except for the drivers. You have four drivers. Three of them have worked

a Tuesday somewhere in that fourteen months and been off on another. One has never missed one.” He looked at the table, not at Dirk. “It is not a syndicate. It is a man with a key and a printer, and he has been doing it alone, badly, for a long time, and he is not clever. You did not catch him because nobody was counting on the day the counting mattered.”

Nobody said anything. The compressor cut out and the room got very loud with quiet.

“Which driver,” said Dirk.

“That is not my job,” Piet said. “That is your job, or it is the police’s job, and I would recommend the second one, because if you do it yourself you will do it in front of everybody, and then whatever is left of the trust in your packhouse will be gone by Thursday and you will lose more than nine hundred thousand.”

He stood up, took his pen, and said, “The report is with Ms Adonis. It is forty-one pages. Please read page four.”

And he walked out into the sun on the concrete, and I did the handshakes and the thank-yous and the *ja no, he’s like that*, which is a thing I have said maybe four hundred times in three years, and which I have started to resent saying, and I said it three times in that room alone.

I found him at the car.

He had his back against the door on the shaded side and his eyes closed and his hands flat on his thighs, and his jacket was folded on the roof with the lining out, the way you take off something that has been wet.

I did not say anything. That is the whole skill. It took me eight months to learn it and it is worth more than everything else I do.

I got in, started the engine for the aircon, and waited. He got in after about a minute and a half.

We came down the R44 past the gates, and every one of them had a sticker on it, and every sticker had a number on it, and every number was a promise somebody had bought.

At Klapmuts he still had not spoken. At the N1 interchange I said, “You want food?” and he did not answer, which is not rudeness, whatever they say in the tasting rooms. It is a man who has spent everything he had before nine in the morning making himself legible to nine strangers under a skylight, and has nothing left over for a sentence about food.

I drove. He looked out the window. Somewhere past Kraaifontein he said, “The camera,” and stopped, and I said, “I know,” and that was the conversation.

He would be fine by four. He would be excellent by six. And on Wednesday he would not answer his phone, and I would not phone twice, because Wednesday is not a mystery. Wednesday is just the bill.

I had the Rawsonville file in my bag the whole time.

I didn’t take it out. I was going to give it to him at the office and I knew exactly what would happen when I did — I had known for four days, which is why it had taken me four days — and I want it on the record, since I am the one telling this, that I gave it to him anyway.

Her name was Deline. She had been gone eight months. Her mother had reported her three times.

There was no docket. Not lost. Never opened.

Chapter 2

Our office is one room above Riaan's bicycle shop, up a flight of green-painted stairs that smell like rubber and degreaser all the way to the top, and I want to say something about that smell, which is that it is the only building Piet Buys will walk into without preparing first.

I have watched him do it a hundred times. At the bottom of the stairs he is a man who has been out in the world. By the landing he is not. Somewhere around the fourth step his shoulders come down about two centimetres and stay there. I asked him about it once, early on, when I still asked things, and he said, "It smells the same every day," and I said, "That's it?" and he said, "Yes," in a tone that suggested he could not understand why anybody would want more than that from a building.

I have a lot of theories about Piet. That one I got right the first time and never improved on.

He went straight to the corner and started the kettle and did not say anything for eleven minutes, which is normal for a Monday and was not the reason my heart was going.

The reason my heart was going was in my bag.

The room has two desks that don't match, a printer that we bought used and that we both hate, and one wall that Piet keeps empty on purpose. Not empty like unfurnished. Empty like a rule. In three years I have watched him take down a calendar, a poster from a bike race, and a framed photograph of my daughter's matric dance that I put up without asking, and each time he moved it to the other wall,

carefully, without comment, and each time I understood a little more clearly that the man needs one surface in his life where nothing is happening.

I have my back to that wall now, telling this, so you know how it is going to go.

The kettle clicked. He made the coffee — two, always two, one for him and one for whoever is in the room, which is a piece of manners so consistent it took me a year to notice it was manners — and put mine down on my desk on the coaster, which is a thing I don't use and he has never once mentioned.

"The report went out at 06:40," he said. "Dirk's office acknowledged. He has not read page four."

"He's read page four."

"He acknowledged in four minutes. It is forty-one pages." He sat down. "He read page one and the last page. He will phone on Thursday about page four and be angry with me on the phone in a way he is currently angry with himself."

"You want to bet?"

"No," he said, honestly, and drank his coffee, and I put the file on his desk.

It was not a file. Let me be accurate, because this whole thing turns on paperwork and I am not going to be sloppy about it in my own account.

It was a Checkers packet with a school exercise book in it, a page torn out of a diary, two printed WhatsApp screenshots that a nephew had done at an internet café in Worcester, and a photograph, six by four, of a woman in a red top standing next to a bakkie with her hand up against the sun.

There was no docket number on any of it, because there was no docket.

Piet did not touch it. He looked at it the way he looks at things, which is not the way it goes in the films — there is no leaning in, no squinting, no picking up an object and turning it in the light. He sat

still with his hands on his knees and looked at a Checkers packet on his desk for about forty seconds, and I watched the coffee stop being drunk.

“Whose?” he said.

“Her name is Deline Fortuin. She’s twenty-six. She left Rawsonville on the ninth of last October for eight weeks’ work and she hasn’t been home.”

“Eight weeks is not eight months.”

“No.”

“Who is paying?”

“Nobody’s paying, Piet.”

He said nothing.

“Her mother’s name is Wilhelmina Fortuin. Everyone calls her Aunty Miems. She reported it three times.”

His head came up. “Three.”

“Three.”

“To the same station?”

“Twice at De Doorns, once at Worcester.”

“And the case number?”

And here it is, here is the sentence, and I have said it out loud maybe forty times since and it has never once come out of my mouth easily.

“There isn’t one. It was never opened.”

Now. I want to describe what happened next properly, because people who have heard this story from me before think they know, and what they think they know is wrong.

Nothing dramatic happened. He did not stand up. He did not sweep the desk. His face did not do anything I could photograph and show you.

What happened is that he stopped.

He had been about to put the cup down, and the cup went down, and then his hand stayed on it, and his eyes went to a point about a metre to the left of my head where the empty wall is, and he was gone. Not upset. *Working*. And I sat there and drank my coffee and did not speak, because the one thing I have learned about that state is that the cost of interrupting it is not measured in seconds, it is measured in the rest of the day.

Ninety seconds. I counted, because I count things now; he's contagious.

Then he said, "Not lost."

"No."

"Lost is a thing that happens to a docket. There is no docket. So a person made a decision three separate times, or three people each made it once." He was still looking at the wall. "Which is it?"

"I don't know."

"It matters."

"I know it matters."

"If it is three people it is a culture. If it is one person it is a man." He blinked, and came back into the room, and looked at me for the first time since I put the packet down. "You know the instruction."

"I know the instruction."

"Say it."

I put the cup down. "There's no twenty-four-hour rule. There never was. It's a myth. A missing person is opened immediately and investigated immediately, and if you are the member behind that counter you take the fifty-five A and you fill it in with the complainant standing there, whether she came in at nine in the morning or two in the morning, whether the person is six or sixty, and you give her your name and your cell number before she leaves. That's not a guideline. That's the instruction. Parliament has had to send out a *statement* reminding stations that it is the instruction."

"And she was told to wait."

"She was told to come back tomorrow. Three times. In eight months."

Piet looked at the packet again.

"Then nobody broke the law," he said.

"No."

"Nobody will be disciplined."

"No."

"And there is no record that she was ever there." He said it flatly, no emphasis anywhere in the sentence, which is how you can tell with him. "The state does not know it was asked. That is worse than refusing. A refusal leaves a mark."

Here is the thing I have to put in, because I said I'd be honest in this account and it is the part that doesn't flatter me.

I had had that packet for four days.

Four days I carried a woman's mother's exercise book around in my bag, into a Shoprite, to my sister's on the Saturday, to the estate on the Monday morning while we talked about a man stealing wine on Tuesdays. And people will say, ag, Charl, you were being careful, you were checking it first, you wanted to be sure before you took it to him.

I was sure on the first afternoon. Any FCS detective would have been sure by the second cup of tea.

What I was doing for four days was deciding whether to hand a man like Piet Buys a thing like that, because I knew — I *knew*, the way you know the weather is coming before you see it — that once he had it he would not be able to put it down. Not wouldn't. Couldn't. That is not a figure of speech about a determined man. That is a description of how he is built. He will not sleep properly again until it closes, and some of these never close, and I have seen what a thing that does not close does to him and I did not want to be the person who handed him one.

I handed it to him anyway. Because Deline Fortuin was twenty-six and her mother had asked three times, and I could carry the packet or I could carry that, and I have carried that one before and I know what it costs and it costs more.

He can pay his bill. I have to pay mine either way.

“Do you want the background,” I said, “or do you want to go?”

He was already standing. He does not do the thing where he announces it.

“Where does she live?”

“Rawsonville.”

“Then we go now, and you talk,” he said, “and I will not talk, because she has told this three times to people who did not write it down, and if I ask her to start again from the beginning she will do it, and it will cost her more than it costs us, and we will get less.”

He took his jacket off the back of the chair, and then he stopped, and he put it back.

“Not the jacket,” he said, mostly to himself. “Not in a kitchen.”

And I want to be very clear that this is what people are talking about when they say he doesn’t understand people. He had the whole thing worked out before we were down the stairs: who talks, why she must not be made to start again, and what a jacket says in a kitchen in Rawsonville about who is sitting at the table and who is being interviewed.

He gets it wrong sometimes. God knows. I’m going to tell you about the time he got it wrong and a man nearly died for it, and I’m not going to soften that.

But this idea people have, that he doesn’t understand — no. He understands. He just can’t do it and be in a room at the same time.

We took the N1 out past Paarl with the mountains going brown-gold on the left and the trucks coming down the pass at us out of the heat, and Piet did not say one word for fifty minutes, and I let him have it, because he was going to need it.

Chapter 3

The house was in a street where every house had a wire fence and a gate, and none of the gates had a sticker on them, and I noticed that I had noticed it, and I thought, *thanks, Piet*.

Aunt Miems Fortuin was sixty-one and about a metre and a half of her, and she had done her hair. That is the detail I have never been able to get out. We had phoned at nine that morning, from the office, forty minutes' notice, and she had done her hair and put out a cloth on the table and there were biscuits from a shop, on a plate, arranged.

She had had eight months of nobody coming. So when somebody came, she did her hair.

"Kom in, kom in," she said. "Julle het gery. Sit."

Piet said, "Dankie, Mevrouw Fortuin," and sat where she pointed, which was the chair with its back to the window and the door in front of him, and I saw him take it and I saw him notice that he had been given it rather than taken it, and something in his shoulders let go.

"Miems," she said. "Nobody says Mevrouw Fortuin except the municipality."

"Miems," he said, and then he did not say anything else for two hours and eleven minutes.

I want to describe the kitchen and I am aware that this is the part where a certain kind of writer starts doing poverty. So let me be careful, because Aunt Miems would take my head off.

It was a good kitchen. Small, hot, spotless, a fridge with a Vodacom

magnet and a school photo of a boy with his tie crooked, a pot cooking that she'd started before we arrived because we were coming at eleven and eleven is near enough to lunch that you don't let people leave without eating. There was a cross on the wall and a certificate from a church next to it in a frame, and on the counter a Tupperware of dried apricots from a farm that she gave me half of when we left and that I ate in the car and could not swallow properly.

She poured tea. She asked about the drive. She asked whether we'd come past De Doorns or over the pass. She asked me where I was from and when I said Mitchells Plain she said *ja* in a particular way, and I said *ja* back, and that was a whole conversation and it took two seconds.

Then she said, "So. Where must I start."

And I said, "Wherever you want, Aunty. I've got the whole day."

She looked at me for a second. And then she started, and she did not start with the ninth of October. She started with Deline at seven years old and a bicycle with no chain on it, and I let her, and Piet sat with his hands flat on his knees and did not move, and outside a dog was going on about something and the pot ticked on the stove.

Deline Fortuin, twenty-six. The middle one. Two brothers, one in Worcester at a tyre place, one who does not phone.

Matric, and this is a thing Miems said twice, in the same words both times: *sy het haar matriek klaargemaak*. She finished it. She got the certificate. It is in the tin.

Then eight years of the thing that happens, which is that there is no work that is work, so you do seasons. Grapes from December through to about March. Then whatever. Packhouse if you're lucky, and you're lucky if you're known. She had done Ceres. She had done Wolseley. She had done one long stretch in a packhouse in Wellington that she liked because it was inside and it was regular and the supervisor was a woman.

"En sy stuur geld," said Miems. "Elke maand. Sonder dat ek vra."

Every month, without being asked. That went in my book with the date, because money is a record even when nothing else is.

“How did she get the work?” I asked.

“Deur die mense.”

“Which people?”

And Miems made a movement with her hand that I have seen my own mother make, and it means: the arrangement, the way of things, the men who come with the bakkies. Not a person. A weather system.

“Was it always the same one?”

“Nee.” She thought about it, and she was careful, and I want that on the record too, because when this all came out afterwards there were people who said the families were confused, the families couldn’t give a straight story. She was not confused. She was being careful in a way that most witnesses are not, because she had been over it three thousand times in the dark. “Verskillendes. Maar hulle ken mekaar.”

Different ones. But they know each other.

On the ninth of October Deline left for eight weeks. Not grapes — early citrus, up past Citrusdal, that’s what she said, and eight weeks would have brought her back the first week of December, in time for the December work if she wanted it and in time for Christmas either way.

She phoned on the eleventh. Two days in. Said the place was fine, said the room was fine, said there were four of them in it, said one of the girls was from Lesotho and could do hair. Miems told me what Deline said about the hair for about four minutes and every word of it went in my book.

Then nothing.

Not “then a strange silence.” Nothing is normal. Signal up there is signal. Data costs money. People go quiet for two weeks at a time and it means nothing at all, and that is exactly, precisely the gap this whole thing lives inside.

On the twenty-ninth she messaged. Two lines. One of the two screen-shots the nephew printed. It said *hi ma alles reg hier* and then a second one, eleven minutes later, that said *ek sal Vrydag bel*.

She did not phone on the Friday. Or the next one.

The first week of December came and Deline did not come home, and Miems told herself the season had run long, which happens, which happens constantly, which is the most ordinary thing in the world.

Christmas came. Deline did not come home.

“En toe het ek geweet,” she said.

Then I knew.

She did not cry when she said it. She said it the way you say a thing you have already said to yourself so many times that it has worn smooth. She got up in the middle of it and stirred the pot, because the pot needed stirring, and sat down again.

The three times.

The first time was the fourth of January. De Doorns station. She stood in the queue with her sister-in-law and got to the counter and said her daughter had not come back from work.

She was asked how old the daughter was. Twenty-six.

She was asked whether they had had a fight.

She was asked whether the daughter had a boyfriend.

She was told that a grown woman is allowed to go where she likes, and that people come back after the season, and that she must come back if the daughter is not home by the end of the month.

She said thank you. That is the part. She said thank you, and went home, and waited another twenty-six days, because a man behind a counter had told her a thing with authority and she had been raised to believe it.

The second time was the thirtieth of January, same station, different member. This time she had the photograph with her. She was told that they cannot open a case for somebody who went for work, and that she must go to the farm and ask the farm, and that if the farm says the person left, then the person left.

She went to the farm. Two taxis and a lift. The farm office had a woman who was very nice to her and who looked in a book and said there was no Fortuin, D. on the list for that season, and Miems said that's not possible, and the woman said, well, sometimes they come through a contractor and then they're not on our list, they're on his.

Whose?

The woman did not know. The woman was sorry.

The third time was the middle of March, at Worcester, because somebody had told her Worcester was better. At Worcester a member listened to the whole story, which was more than she'd got before, and then said that this was De Doorns's area and she must report it at De Doorns.

She did not go a fourth time.

I asked her why not, and she said — and this is the sentence, this is the one, out of two hours and eleven minutes this is the one I still have —

“Ek het nie meer 'n storie gehad nie.”

I didn't have a story anymore.

Because that's what it does. You go three times and every time you have to make it smaller to fit across a counter, and by the third time you've said it so short and so fast and so apologetically that you can hear how it sounds, and it sounds like nothing, and you start to believe the version you've been forced to tell.

I told her the truth then. I had decided in the car that I would and I did it while I still had the nerve.

I said: Aunty, there is no twenty-four-hour rule. There is no month rule. There is no rule that a grown woman must be gone a certain time. The instruction is that they open it that day, the day you walk in, and they take a form called a fifty-five A, and they fill it in with you standing there, and they put her photograph on the system, and they give you the name of a detective and a number you can phone. That is not me being kind to you. That is the standing instruction and it was the standing instruction on the fourth of January.

She sat very still.

Then she said, "So hulle het gelieg."

And this is where I had to be careful, and I wasn't as careful as I should have been, and I've thought about it since.

I said: No. I don't think anybody sat there deciding to lie to you. I think a tired person said a thing that everybody says, that isn't true, and has never been true, and that thousands of people believe including people wearing the uniform. Which is worse. Because a lie has somebody standing behind it. This has nobody standing behind it at all.

"Dis nie beter nie," she said.

"No, Aunt. It's not better."

She got up and stirred the pot again for a long time.

Piet stood up at ten to two.

Two hours and eleven minutes, and the man had not said one word since *Miems*, and I could see what it had cost him because I know where to look — the hands had come off the knees and gone flat on the table about an hour in, which is his tell, and he had not touched the tea, and there was a fine tremor going in his left leg that had been going for a while.

He said, "Mevrou Fortuin—"

"Miems."

"Miems." He stopped. Started again. "I am going to ask you for one thing and then we will go, and I am sorry that it is a strange thing."

She waited.

"When Deline went — this time, in October — did anybody give her a piece of paper?"

Aunt Miems looked at him.

"A slip," he said. "Or a card. Or a number written down. Something from the man with the bakkie, or from an office. It would be small."

It would say a farm, or a week, or a number. It would not look important.”

And I watched a thing happen in that kitchen that I have thought about for two years since.

She got up. She went into the passage. We heard a cupboard, and a chair being moved, and then she came back with a Quality Street tin, the old kind, and she put it on the table and took off the lid, and inside was a funeral policy, an ID book, a birth certificate for a boy, three photographs, a matric certificate with a green cover — *sy het haar matriek klaargemaak* — and a gold-coloured watch that did not go.

And under all of it, folded twice, a piece of paper about the size of a till slip.

It had a cellphone number on it, and a date, and *CITRUS 8W*, and in the corner somebody had written **C4** and circled it.

“Dit was in haar baadjie,” said Miems. “Sy het dit gelos. Ek het dit gehou omdat dit hare was.”

It was in her jacket. She left it behind. I kept it because it was hers.

Nobody had ever asked her for it. Not once, in eight months, at three counters, at one farm office. Not because anybody was hiding anything. Because nobody had ever opened anything, and if you do not open anything you do not ask for anything, and a piece of paper in a tin in a passage is not evidence, it is a mother keeping her daughter's things.

Piet did not touch it either. He said, “May I photograph it?”

“Ja.”

He photographed it, on the table, without picking it up, four times, from four angles, and then he put his phone in his pocket and said, “Thank you. That is the only thing anybody has that is worth anything, and you kept it for eight months, and you did not know that you were doing it.”

Which was — I want to say clumsy, and it wasn't. She heard it exactly right. She put her hand flat on the tin.

“Sal julle my bel?” she said. “Al is dit sleg nuus. Bel my.”

"Yes," I said.

"Every Friday," said Piet, "whether there is news or not. That is easier than waiting for the phone to ring."

He was right about that. He is right about that in a way that most people who are kinder than him never work out, and I have used it a hundred times since with a hundred families, and I got it from him, in that kitchen, at two o'clock in the afternoon.

She made us take food. Of course she did. She stood at the gate with her arms folded while I turned the car, and she was still standing there when we came round the corner, and I looked in the mirror and she had not moved.

We got to the R43 and Piet said, "C4."

"Crew four."

"Crew four." He was looking out of the window. "There is a crew one, two and three."

I did not answer, because he wasn't talking to me.

"And a crew five," he said.

Chapter 4

Here is how you find a missing woman in this country, if you are Piet Buys and it is a Tuesday.

You do not go to the police, because there is nothing at the police. You do not go to a laboratory, because there is nothing to put in it. You do not go and look at where she was last seen, because nobody knows where she was last seen and the last person who could have told you is at a farm office in a book that does not have her name in it.

You sit in a room above a bicycle shop with your phone and a laptop and you look at *advertisements*.

I got there at half past seven on the Tuesday. The kettle was cold, which told me it had been boiled a long time ago, and the window was open, which told me it had been shut all night and opened recently for the smell, and Piet was at his desk in yesterday's shirt with his phone face-down next to him.

"Have you been here since I dropped you?"

"No."

"Piet."

"I went home. I came back." He did not look up. "At approximately two."

"That's not—"

"I know what it is not."

I put the kettle on. There is no argument to have there. I have had the argument. The argument produces a man who lies to you about

when he came back, and I would rather have a man who tells me two.

“The number on the slip is a WhatsApp Business account,” he said. “The display name is Ashwin. The profile photograph is a Toyota Hilux, white, single cab, taken in a yard with a blue gate. The business description says *Arbeid & Vervoer* and gives a Facebook page. The Facebook page has four hundred and eleven followers and posts work.”

“Posts work how?”

“The way everybody posts work.” He turned the laptop round.

And there it was, and I had seen a hundred of these and never once looked at one properly.

8 WEKE CITRUS. VERVOER GEREËL. KOS EN BLYPLEK. VROUE WELKOM. WHATSAPP ASHWIN.

Eight weeks. Transport arranged. Food and a place to stay. Women welcome.

Under it, forty-one comments, and every single one of them said the same thing in a different way, which was: me. Ek. My. Ek soek werk. Ek is beskikbaar. Ek het ervaring. Some of them had put their phone numbers straight into the comments, in public, under a post, because that is what you do when you need work and there are four hundred other people who also need it and speed is the whole strategy.

Forty-one women had put their names in public under an advertisement.

“Jissie,” I said.

“Yes.”

“And that’s — that’s not even suspicious. That’s just—”

“That is a labour market,” said Piet. “That is the entire labour market. There is nothing wrong with that page.”

He had gone back through nineteen months of it. Not skimmed. Back. Every post, every comment, screenshotted into a folder that was already four hundred files deep at seven in the morning.

"What am I looking for?"

"Nothing," he said. "You are not looking for anything. Neither am I. That is the mistake." He scrolled. "If I look for something I will find it. There are eleven thousand comments. I will find any shape I decide to find."

"So what are you doing?"

"Reading them."

"All of them?"

"Yes."

I sat down with my coffee and watched him read comments on a Facebook page for two and a half hours, and I want you to understand that this is the actual job, and that no one has ever filmed it.

At twenty past eleven he said, "Bernadine Klaasen."

"What?"

"October the second, last year. She comments on the citrus post. She says she has done Ceres, she gives a cellphone number, she asks whether it is Crew Four because her cousin is in Crew Four." He did not turn round. "On the fourth of October she posts on her own page a photograph of a bag packed on a bed with a caption that says *Bloemfontein toe? Nee wat. Citrusdal toe.*"

"Okay."

"On the twenty-eighth of October somebody posts on her page and asks if she is okay."

"Okay—"

"On the ninth of November her sister posts *asseblief as iemand my suster sien*. Two people share it. On the twenty-second of December her sister posts a photograph of a birthday cake with her name on it and writes *ons wag nog.*"

We're still waiting.

"And then?" I said.

"And then nothing. That is the last post on the account. It has been eight months."

I put my cup down.

"Piet, that's — that's one woman on a page with four hundred followers. There could be fifty explanations—"

"Forty-one," he said. "There could be forty-one explanations. I have thought of thirty-one of them. Nine survive." He finally turned round. "She could be alive somewhere and estranged. She could be in another province. She could have gone to Namibia; people do. She could be in a hospital. She could be in a prison. She could be in a mortuary in Malmesbury under a number." He said all of that completely flatly, no rush, like a man reading a stock list. "That is not the point. The point is that her sister posted *asseblief* on the ninth of November, and eight months later there are two shares and no case number, and I found her in one morning from a public page using nothing that is not available to a child."

He turned back to the screen.

"Anyone could have found her," he said. "Nobody was looking. That is the whole finding. That is what I have found this morning."

Now here is the thing about him that the films get wrong, and I said I'd explain it properly.

He did not, at any point, tell me how he got there. He never does. He gave me a name at twenty past eleven and that was it — no *you* see, *Adonis*, no chain, no working. It took me two days and a notebook to reconstruct what he had actually done, and when I finally had it and read it back to him he listened with an expression of mild discomfort, like a man being read his own poetry, and said, "Yes," and went back to what he was doing.

I asked him once, later, in the Northern Cape, why he never explains.

He said: "Because the explaining is the part I am trying to get away from."

I said I didn't understand.

He said, "The chain is not a pleasure to me. It is what happens instead of sleeping. You want me to perform it as though it is a card trick I chose to do." And then, because he saw my face, and he is not unkind, he added: "It is not a card trick. It is a tap I cannot close."

The bill came due on the Wednesday.

I phoned once at eight to say I had Bernadine Klaasen's sister's number and a meeting on Friday. It rang out. I did not phone again, because Wednesday is not a mystery.

I drove out to Rawsonville alone, because it was Friday in three days and I had promised Aunty Miems a call and I wanted to be able to say a true thing to her. Then I came back and did my invoices and went home and made supper for my daughter and did not think about any of it for four hours, which is a professional skill and I am not ashamed of it.

He came in at half past nine on the Thursday morning, shaved, in a clean shirt, with a lever-arch file under his arm and the flat calm of a man who has slept twelve hours in a row.

"Three," he said, and put the file on my desk.

Chapter 5

Ashwin Damon ran his business off the back of a white Hilux single cab outside a Cash & Carry in De Doorns, and he was, I want to say this at the start, one of the more pleasant men I have interviewed in twenty years.

That is not a joke and it is not sarcasm. He was polite. He got us two cold drinks out of the shop and would not take the money. He had a clipboard with a bulldog clip on it and a phone in a case with a card slot in the back and he answered every question I asked him, immediately, without lawyering, without once asking who we were with. He assumed we were with somebody. Everybody assumes.

“Fortuin,” he said, and went down the clipboard with a pen. “Fortuin. Fortuin, D. Ja. Sy was by my.”

She was with me.

“October?”

“October. Citrus. Agt weke.” He turned the clipboard round so I could see it, which I want on the record, because he did not have to do that and nobody had asked him to in eight months because nobody had asked him anything in eight months. “Crew four. Sixteen people. Elf vroue.”

“Do you have the list?”

“Dis die lys.” The clipboard. That was the list. One page, sixteen lines, in pen, some of the lines with only a first name on them.

“Do you keep them?”

He looked genuinely puzzled. “Hoekom?”

And there it is. Why would he. The page is not a record for anybody's benefit; it is how he remembers who to pay on the Friday. When the season ends the page's job is finished. He had this one because it was still in the clip, under three newer ones, the way a receipt stays in your wallet.

"Did she come back?"

"Ek weet nie."

"You don't know?"

"Ek vat hulle op, ek vat hulle terug." He shrugged, not defensively — explanatorily, like a man describing a job to somebody who has never had one. "Party klim af by die pad. Party bly aan vir die volgende plek. Party gaan huis toe met 'n taxi." He tapped the clipboard. "Ek tel nie koppe op die pad terug nie. Ek's nie hulle pa nie."

I take them up, I take them back. Some get off at the road. Some stay on for the next place. Some go home by taxi. I don't count heads on the way back. I'm not their father.

I said, "Somebody phoned you about her. Her mother phoned this number."

"Baie mense bel my."

"In January. She'd have said Fortuin."

He thought about it. Actually thought — I watched him do it, and I believe he was trying.

"Ek onthou nie," he said. And then, and this is the part, this is the part I had to sit in the car about afterwards: "Mevrou, ek kry twintig, dertig oproepe 'n dag. Almal soek werk."

He wasn't refusing me. He was telling me the truth about his day. Twenty, thirty calls a day, all of them people looking for work, and somewhere in January one of them was a woman looking for her daughter, and it went into the same ear as all the others and out again, and the man is not a monster, he is a man with a phone that rings thirty times a day.

Piet had not said anything. He was standing about two metres off with his back half to us, looking at the Hilux.

“Meneer Damon,” he said.

“Ashwin.”

“Ashwin. Who told you to take sixteen?”

“Die plaas.”

“Which farm?”

“Wat’s dit werd vir jou?”

I started to say something and Piet said, “Nothing. I have no money for you and no authority over you and you can stop this conversation whenever you like.” Flat, no edge on it at all. “I am asking because your crew four had sixteen and eleven of them were women, and that is a high proportion for citrus, and it is not a high proportion for a packhouse, and I would like to know whether the farm asked you for women or whether you sent women.”

Ashwin looked at him for a second.

“Hulle vra,” he said.

“The farm asks.”

“Almal vra.” Everybody asks. “Vroue werk vinniger op die lyn. En hulle drink nie.” He said it without any expression at all, a fact about his trade. “Ek’s nie die een wat vra nie. Ek vul net in.”

I’m not the one who asks. I just fill it.

Piet nodded once, and went back to looking at the bakkie.

I got the farm’s name out of him in the end, and it was a real farm, and it existed, and I want to be clear about that because of what everybody assumed afterwards. There was no fake farm. There was no shell company. The work was real. The wage was real, thirty rand and something an hour, cash on a Friday, and short by a little in a way that is impossible to prove and that everybody accepts.

Only the destination wasn’t. Only for some of them. Only sometimes.

That is what took so long. That is why it ran for years. If a man invents a farm, somebody eventually phones the farm. Nobody ever phones a farm that exists to ask whether a woman who is on nobody's list arrived at a place she was never officially going.

On the way back to the car Piet stopped in the middle of the parking area and stood still.

I know that stop. It is not a thought arriving. It is the opposite — it is the moment when too many things arrive at once and the body just parks while it happens. He gets it in supermarkets. He was getting it now next to a trolley bay in thirty-four degrees.

I went and stood between him and the Cash & Carry doors, which is a thing I do, because it takes about a third of the noise out of the frame, and I waited.

"Sixteen," he said, eventually.

"Ja."

"He has a page for crew four. He has one page. He has kept it by accident." He was talking at the tar. "There is no page for last year. There is no page for the year before. There is no page anywhere in this country for the year before that." A pause. "The farm has a list. The farm's list does not have her on it. So the only place Deline Fortuin ever existed as a worker is a piece of paper in a bulldog clip, and it survives because he has not thrown it away yet."

"So we take it."

"We ask for it. He will give it to us. He gave you the cold drink." He breathed out. "That is not the problem. The problem is that there are five crews, and eleven women in one of them, and eight weeks, and this valley has been doing this every season since before I was born, and *nobody has ever counted.*"

We had lunch at a place on the main road because he needed to eat and because I have learned to make it happen before it is a crisis rather than after.

The woman who brought the food was about my age, and she and I got talking the way you do, and she asked what we were doing there, and I said we were looking for somebody who went out with a crew and didn't come home.

She said, "Wanneer?"

I said October.

And she said, "Ag, dis moeilik. Hier's baie mense wat gaan en nie kom nie. Veral ná 2009."

There's a lot of people here who go and don't come. Especially after 2009.

She said it the way you say a year. Not an event, not a story, not something she was explaining to me — a marker on a road, the way somebody else would say *before the pass was tarred*. Then she asked if we wanted more Coke.

I have thought about that woman more than almost anybody else in this. She gave me, in eleven words, over a plate of chips, the answer to the question that took us the next four months and two thousand kilometres to ask properly.

Piet did not react. He ate about a third of what was in front of him, which for him is a good day, and looked out the window at the mountains going up out of the valley on both sides, and the trucks, and the vines in their long green lines running right up to the foot of the rock.

Then he said, "We need the other four pages."

"They don't exist."

"No," he said. "But the farms' pages do. And SARS's do. And the fuel does." He put his fork down. "Everybody is very bad at keeping a list of people. Everybody in this country is extremely good at keeping a list of money."

Chapter 6

By the Wednesday there were six, and the floor of the office had disappeared.

Not a metaphor. He had cleared the desks and laid it out on the floorboards in columns, A4 pages weighted with a stapler, a mug, a bicycle chain tool that Riaan lent him without asking what it was for, and my daughter's matric dance photograph in its frame, face-down, doing service as a paperweight, which is a sentence I enjoy more every year.

One column per woman. Six columns. Each column: the advertisement, the comment with her name under it, her own page, the last post, and then the posts by other people afterwards, which are always the worst ones, because they go on for a while and then they stop.

Down the left, along the skirting board, he had laid out dates.

"Don't step there," he said, without looking up, as I came in the door.

"Môre to you too."

"There is coffee."

There was. There always is. Two cups.

Bernadine Klaasen, 24. Ceres, then citrus. Last seen going.

Neliswa Mgcini, 31. Two children in the Eastern Cape. Sent money on the 15th of the month for eleven months and then did not.

Amoret Booysen, 22. From Touwsrivier. Her page has a video of her doing a dance with two other girls in a packhouse uniform and it

has been shared eighty times since she stopped posting, by people saying please.

Sylvia Tafira, 28. No page at all. Found because her name is in a comment thread under somebody else's post, twice, a year apart.

Deline Fortuin, 26.

And one whose name we only had as *Mmapula*, no surname, because she existed on a broker's page for one afternoon in February two years ago and then never again anywhere on the internet at all.

"That's not enough for Mmapula," I said. "You can't put her up."

"I know."

"Then why is she up?"

"Because taking her down is also a decision," he said, "and I do not want to make it at speed."

Here is what I have never been able to explain properly to people who ask what he actually does.

He did not have a theory. That is the thing. Four days in and there was no theory, and every time I tried to give him one — a man, a route, a type — he would let it sit for a moment and then set it down somewhere out of the way like a cup you've handed him when he's busy.

"You're not going to say it," I said on the Wednesday. "Are you."

"Say what."

"Serial."

He looked at the floor for a while.

"That word does two things," he said. "One of them is useful. It tells a station commander that these six dockets are one docket, and it is the only word in the language that makes anybody move resources." He pushed a page a centimetre with his foot. "The other thing it does is make everybody in the building start thinking about a *man*. His childhood. His signature. What he is like. And the moment they

are thinking about him they have stopped counting women, and the counting is the whole job.”

“So we don’t say it.”

“We say it to exactly one person, once, when it will move something.”
He crouched down at the end of the row of dates. “Not before.”

The bill, that week, was strange, and I have to write it honestly because it wasn’t the bad kind.

He was *up*. Sleeping badly, eating when I put it in front of him, wearing the same two shirts, but lit — genuinely, cleanly lit, in a way that the tasting room at the estate never made him and never could. He talked more that week than in the whole month before it. He was funny twice, both times by accident.

I have thought about this a lot. Everybody wants the story where the gift is a curse. It isn’t that. The truth is worse and more ordinary: this is the only thing that has ever fitted him exactly, and the thing that fits him exactly is a floor covered in dead women, and he knows that, and he does not have a comfortable place to put it.

He said one thing about it, on the Thursday, at about eleven at night, when we were both too tired to be careful.

He said, “It is the only time it is not a defect.”

I said, “It’s never a defect, Piet.”

And he said, “That is very kind and you have not been me,” and then he apologised, immediately, in a formal way that made it worse, and we did not talk for about twenty minutes.

He was right, though. That’s the thing. He was right and I said the nice thing instead of the true one, and I know better than that, and I did it anyway because it was eleven at night and I wanted him to feel better.

The seventh came on the Thursday. The eighth an hour later — they were cousins, which is why. The ninth on the Friday morning at ten

past eight, and by then he had stopped saying the names out loud when he found them, and just wrote them on the wall.

The empty wall. He had taken the paper across onto the empty wall.

I did not say anything about that either. But I noticed, and I want it in this account, because about two months later I would have to make a decision about this man on very little sleep and with a great deal at stake, and the evidence I used to make it started on that Friday morning at ten past eight.

At eleven o'clock I phoned Aunt Miems, because it was Friday and because we had said every Friday.

"Aunty, it's Charl."

"Charl." A pause. Every single time, that pause, and every single time I hear in it a woman deciding how much to hope before I've said anything. "Is daar nuus?"

"There's no news about Deline. I'm phoning because it's Friday."

"Ja," she said. "Ja, nee, dankie."

And then we talked for eleven minutes about a leak in her roof and about her grandson's report and about the fact that I had eaten all the apricots in the car, which made her laugh, properly, and I came off that phone and sat on the stairs outside the office for a minute.

Piet was standing in the doorway when I came back up.

"She is all right?"

"She's all right."

"You did not tell her there are nine."

"No."

"Good," he said. "Not yet. When we tell her there are nine, she will understand immediately that Deline is dead, and she will be right, and there is no reason for her to know that on a Friday when we cannot also tell her what happened."

He said it exactly as flatly as he says everything else, and I stood in the doorway of my own office and had to look at the floor for a

second.

Because that — that right there — is the man that people in tasting rooms call cold. He had thought it through in advance, the whole way through, to the end, to what it would do to a sixty-one-year-old woman in Rawsonville on a Friday afternoon with the rest of the weekend in front of her and nobody in the house.

He gets there by a different road than you and me. He gets there.

Chapter 7

I had the map wrong for four days and so did he, and I want that in, because afterwards everybody talked about it as though he had looked at nine names and seen it whole.

We had a map. Riaan came up with it — an old AA road map of the Western and Northern Cape, the paper kind, with the fold lines gone furry — and he stood in the doorway with it under his arm and said, “Ek het gehoor julle soek ’n kaart,” and Piet said, “Thank you, Riaan,” and Riaan said, “Bring dit terug,” and went back downstairs, and that was the entire transaction, and it is the only friendship I have ever watched Piet Buys conduct without visible effort.

We put pins in it. Nine pins. And the nine pins made a shape that looked like something, which is the most dangerous thing a map can do.

They went up the country. De Doorns, Worcester, Touwsrivier, then Citrusdal, then Clanwilliam, then two in the Northern Cape near Kakamas, and one, right at the top, at Keimoes.

“It’s the N7,” I said. “It’s the road.”

“It is a road,” said Piet.

“It’s a corridor, Piet, that’s — look at it. That’s a straight line.”

“It is a straight line because the country is a straight line.” He was on the floor with his back against the desk. “There are four roads north. Everything is on one of them. If I put pins in nine weddings they would also make a corridor.”

“So what, it means nothing?”

"It means what it says. It says that women who go for seasonal work travel on the roads that go to seasonal work." He rubbed his eyes with the heels of his hands. "It is a map of the agriculture. I have made a map of agriculture."

He was flat for two days after that. Not the Wednesday kind of flat — a duller thing, a man who has been running on the certainty that the shape would arrive and has had it not arrive.

I did the ordinary work. Somebody has to invoice. Dirk phoned on the Thursday about page four, angry in exactly the manner predicted, and I took it and did not tell Piet he'd been right because he would not have enjoyed it.

On the Saturday I went out to Rawsonville and sat with Aunty Miems for two hours, off the clock, and we did the roof and her grandson and a long thing about her sister-in-law, and on the way home I stopped at the top of the pass and looked down at the valley in the late light, the whole of it, the vines in their lines and the packhouses with their roofs going pink and the little town, and I thought: eleven women in one crew. Sixteen people. Five crews. One page.

And I thought: how many crews are down there right now.

I phoned him from the top of the pass.

"It's not the road," I said.

"I know it is not the road."

"No, listen. It's not *where*. It's *when*."

There was a silence on the phone that went on long enough that I looked at the screen to see if it had dropped.

"Say that again," he said.

"October ninth. Deline goes for eight weeks of citrus. That's the shoulder — grapes aren't started yet, citrus is just going. Bernadine's the second of October. My third one, Neliswa, that's the beginning of March, and the grape season's just ending, so she's between—"

"Say the word again."

"Between."

“Yes,” he said. “Between. Get here.”

I got there at twenty past eight on a Saturday night and he had already taken the pins out.

The map was on the floor and it was blank again and he had turned it over, and on the back of it, on the white side, he had drawn a year. Just a long line across the paper with twelve marks on it.

Then he had put the nine women on it. Not by where. By when.

And they sat on it like teeth.

Not spread. Not random. They clustered in two places on that line, and both places were gaps: the first week of October, when the citrus crews assemble and the grape crews have not; and the last week of March into April, when the grapes finish and everybody who has been working since December is suddenly, all at once, unemployed and mobile and on a road somewhere with cash in their pocket and no fixed address until the next thing starts.

“The shoulder,” he said.

“The shoulder.”

“That is the window.” He was crouched over it. “It is not a place. It is a condition. It is the six to nine days in which a woman has left one arrangement and has not yet arrived at the next, and during which *there is no one on earth who expects to hear from her.*” He looked up at me. “Her mother does not expect a phone call, because she is travelling. The old farm does not expect her, because the contract is finished. The new farm does not expect her, because the crew has not been called yet. The broker does not expect her, because he has not counted a head since the ninth of October.”

“And that’s not eight days,” I said. “That’s—”

“That is eight days in which she vanishes, and then six weeks in which nobody is surprised, and then a season in which people begin to wonder, and then a year in which people assume, and then she is gone.” He sat back on his heels. “The disappearance is eight days. The *silence* is engineered by the calendar. He is not hiding anything. He does not have to hide anything. The system hides the absence for

him, for free, every year, twice a year, and it has been doing it since before he started and it will do it after he stops.”

I sat down on the floor.

“How long,” I said.

“How long what?”

“How long has he been doing it? If the window’s twice a year and nobody notices for a year—”

And Piet Buys did the thing he does about once every two months, which is that he did not answer a question.

He got up, and went to the kettle, and boiled it, and made two cups, and put mine down on the coaster I don’t use.

“Piet.”

“Nine is what I can defend,” he said, with his back to me.

“That’s not what I asked.”

“No,” he agreed.

I want to be fair to him about that night, because when it came out later I was angry in a way I am not proud of, and some of that anger was really about being tired.

He was not lying to me. He has never lied to me. He answered exactly the question I should have asked, which is: what can you defend? And nine was what he could defend. Nine had a name, a comment, a last post, a date. Nine you could take to a colonel.

But I had asked how long, and he had heard how many, and he had already run it, days before, on the back of an envelope — I found the envelope afterwards, in the file, because he never throws anything away — and he had put it away in the drawer of his desk with the pages he does not put on the wall.

He was protecting me. Which is a kind thing to do and it is also, exactly and precisely, the thing that goes wrong in the third act of this story.

We drank the coffee sitting on the floor with a map of a year between us, and he said, "On Monday we go to the police," and I said, "Ja," and neither of us said the word out loud, and both of us knew that on Monday somebody was going to have to.

Chapter 8

I went in on the Sunday to type it up.

That is a boring sentence and it is the true one. There was no suspicion in it, no moment where I stood at the bottom of the green stairs and knew. I went in on a Sunday morning because on Monday we were going to sit in front of a colonel of the South African Police Service and ask her to do something with her Tuesday, and Piet cannot write a document that a colonel will read, and I can, and that is the division of labour.

He was not there. His car was not outside. Riaan's shop was shut. The building smelled like rubber and degreaser and Sunday.

I needed the dates for Sylvia Tafira, and the dates for Sylvia Tafira were on the back of a page in his handwriting, and his handwriting was in the desk, and the desk drawer was not locked, and there is nothing in this office of ours that has ever been mine or his, and I have opened that drawer nine hundred times.

The envelope was on top. Bank envelope, the kind with a window. He had done the arithmetic on the back of it in pencil, four lines, and I read it standing up with my bag still on my shoulder.

It said:

9 defensible window $\times 2/\text{yr}$ assume 60% below detection
(no page / no post / not SA) assume 40% of remainder
never reported ≥ 22 in 4 yrs. ≥ 30 if from '19.

I put the envelope down on the desk. Then I picked it up again and looked at the last line for a while.

If from '19.

Not *since 2019*. Not *starting in*. **If**. A man testing a hypothesis he already had.

Under the envelope was the file.

Not a folder — a proper lever-arch, the maroon one that had been standing on the shelf behind his desk for as long as I have worked in that room. I had assumed it was tax. There is a maroon lever-arch in every small business in this country and it is always tax.

It was not tax. It was thirty-one pages, and the first page had a date at the top in his handwriting, and the date was the fourth of March, three years before Auntie Miems put a Checkers packet on his desk.

I stood in the middle of the office and read the whole thing standing up and did not sit down once, and at some point I put my bag on the floor and did not notice doing it.

They were not cases. That's the thing that took me longest to understand and it is the thing that matters.

They were *absences of cases*.

Page after page of them. A note from a Facebook page. A screenshot of a comment. A newspaper item four lines long from a community paper in Vredendal. Somebody's WhatsApp status. A photograph of a photocopied flyer taped to a shop window in Kakamas, with a face on it and a cell number and the word ASSEMBLIEF, taken from an angle that told you a man had stopped his car and got out and taken it and got back in and driven on.

Some pages had one line. *Woman, name given as Sanna, Clan-william, March, no surname obtained, no docket found on enquiry*. Some had four. Almost none of them had anything that would survive anywhere near a court.

Every page had the same three-word note at the bottom in the same pencil.

No case number.

Thirty-one pages of it. Three years of a man driving between wine estates writing risk assessments for people with electric fences, stopping at shop windows.

I sat down eventually. On the floor, with my back to the desk, where he sits.

Because here is what I understood, sitting there, and it went through me in about four seconds and then took me two months to be able to say out loud.

He did not find a pattern in Deline Fortuin's file.

He had had the pattern for three years. Three years of a shape with no name on it, a suspicion he could not defend to anybody, could not take to a station, could not fund, could not prove, and could not put down — because he cannot put anything down, that is the entire architecture of the man — and then on a Monday morning in an office above a bicycle shop a woman he trusts put a Checkers packet on his desk with a slip of paper in it that said CITRUS 8W and C4, and he looked at a wall for ninety seconds.

I thought he had been thinking.

He had been *confirming*.

And then he had said, *Not lost*, and I had thought, God, look at him go.

There was one more thing in the drawer and I nearly did not lift it, and I have wondered since what the last two years would have looked like if I hadn't.

Under the maroon file, flat on the bottom of the drawer, was a single sheet of A4, folded in three, soft at the folds the way paper goes when it has been opened a great many times.

It was a photocopy of a page out of an occurrence book. The station stamp at the top was smudged but readable.

Upington.

The date was eleven years old.

I did not read it. I want that on the record — I stood there with it in my hands and I looked at the date and the station and I put it back exactly as it had been, folded in three, flat on the bottom of the drawer, under the maroon file, and I closed the drawer.

Not because I am a good person. Because I was frightened.

He came in at twenty past four in the afternoon and I was at my desk with the Monday document three-quarters typed and the maroon file squared up on the corner of his desk in front of his chair.

He looked at it. He looked at me. He did not perform surprise and he did not perform being caught, and God, I would have given a lot for him to perform something.

He hung his jacket on the back of the chair and sat down.

“Ask,” he said.

“Three years?”

“Three years and four months.”

“Piet—”

“There is no case.” He said it before I could get there, and there was something underneath the flat this time, the first time in three years I had heard anything underneath it. “There is no case, Adonis. There are thirty-one pieces of paper and not one of them is a docket. There is no complainant. There is no crime scene. There is no body. There is no forensic. There is nothing that any human being on this earth can do anything with, and I have known that for three years and four months and I have known it every single day.”

“You could have told me.”

“Yes.”

“So why—”

“Because you would have believed me,” he said.

And that stopped me completely.

“You would have believed me,” he said again, “on nothing. On thirty-one pieces of paper and a man’s certainty. And then it would have

been two of us carrying it and no more evidence than before, and I have seen what carrying it does, and I was not going to be the reason it happened to you.” He put his hands flat on the desk. “And then you brought me a slip of paper out of a tin, and now it is not thirty-one pieces of paper. Now there are nine women with names and dates on a wall and a page in a bulldog clip in De Doorns, and *now* it can be told to somebody, and now I have told you.”

I sat there for a bit.

“Nine’s what we take to Nyathi tomorrow,” I said.

“Nine is what we take.”

“And the rest?”

“The rest stays in the drawer,” said Piet, “because if I put thirty-one unsourced pages in front of a colonel of the South African Police Service on a Monday morning, she will be entirely correct to put us out of her office, and we will not get back in.”

He was right about that.

He was right about all of it, and I want to be honest and say that I went home that night and poured the bath and lay in it and thought, *well, thank God, at last, somebody has been counting.*

It took me a long time to work out what was actually wrong with what I’d found, and it was not the three years, and it was not the secrecy.

It was the pencil.

Thirty-one pages, three years, four different districts — and every one of those pages was in the same handwriting, checked by the same man, weighted by the same judgement, and never once, in three years and four months, shown to a single other human being who might have said: *or she just went to Joburg.*

That is not a man building a case.

That is a man building a room with no windows in it, and living in it, and I was about to walk in and close the door behind me.

Movement Two — No Docket

Chapter 9

Colonel Thandeka Nyathi gave us forty minutes on a Monday and used thirty-one of them listening, which is more listening than I got out of the entire South African Police Service in the four years after I left it.

I want that on the record early, because of how this chapter ends.

Her office was on the second floor with a window that did not open and a photograph of a passing-out parade and a whiteboard with nine columns on it, and I did not look at the whiteboard because I did not want to know, and I looked at it anyway, and the nine columns were not our nine.

She had read the document. All of it. She had made marks on it in two colours.

“Adonis,” she said. “You were Mitchells Plain.”

“Ja, Colonel.”

“FCS.”

“Fourteen years.”

“Boarded?”

“Boarded.”

“Mm,” she said, and that was the whole conversation about that, and it was enough, and I have never forgotten that she did it in the first ninety seconds so that we could both stop wondering.

I did the presenting. That was agreed in the car.

Nine women. Names, ages, districts, last contact, last post, the name of the person who noticed first. What existed and what didn't: five had never been reported at all; three had been reported and turned away; one had an actual docket, opened in Springbok, and the docket was open and had been allocated to a detective who had ninety-four other dockets.

Then the calendar. I turned the map over and put the year-line on her desk and walked her along it, and I did it in about four minutes, and when I got to the shoulder she put her pen down.

That's when Piet spoke for the first time.

He said, "It is a serial offender, Colonel. One man, four to seven years, twice a year."

And that was it. That was the once.

Nyathi did not argue with him. She did not say *let's not get ahead of ourselves* and she did not do the thing they do in films where the police officer is contemptuous of the outsider so that the outsider can be vindicated in act three.

She said, "I know who you are."

"Yes."

"You did the linkage on the Vredenburg thing. Two thousand and nineteen."

"I did the analysis. Somebody else did the linkage."

"Mm." She looked at the year-line for a while. Then she said, "It's good. It's a good piece of work and I believe you."

And I felt the whole room tilt about ten degrees toward the good outcome, and I want to describe exactly how long that lasted, and it lasted until she took a breath.

"Here is my Tuesday," she said.

She turned in her chair and pointed at the whiteboard with the nine columns that were not our nine.

"Those are my task teams. Nine of them. Two are on a taxi conflict that has done eleven bodies since February. One is on the tourist-corridor robberies, which I am asked about in writing every ten days, by name. One is on a farm attack that is on television. One is a rape docket where the complainant is fifteen and the accused is out. The other four you don't need."

"Colonel—"

"I have four vehicles that go. I have a forensic backlog that is measured in *years* — not months, years — and I have a DNA queue that is over a hundred and forty thousand cases nationally, and if I send something in today I will get it when the child in that rape docket is at university."

She turned back around.

"You are asking me to open a linked-series investigation across three provinces and a border, on nine women, of whom five have no docket, one has a docket in another district, and none of whom have been found. There is no body. There is no scene. There is no forensic. There is no witness who saw a crime. There is a piece of paper in a bulldog clip in De Doorns."

"That's true," I said.

"I know it's true. I read it twice." She tapped the document. "Now tell me which of those nine columns I take the people off."

Nobody said anything for a bit.

Then Piet said, "The taxi conflict."

I closed my eyes.

"The taxi conflict has eleven bodies since February," he said, "and it will have more, and everybody in this building knows who is doing it and cannot prove it, and the docket is going nowhere and has been going nowhere for five months. It is the least productive use of a task team in this room."

"Piet—"

"It is also the one that is on the Commissioner's list," said Nyathi,

“and the one that has a community forum and a councillor and a WhatsApp group of four hundred people who phone this office.” She said it without heat. “You’ve just told me to take my people off the case that shouts and put them on the case that doesn’t. Do you know what that is called, Mr Buys? That’s called every decision that has ever been made in this country about who gets looked for.”

And Piet Buys sat absolutely still, and I watched the sentence go into him.

Because she was right. She was completely, exactly right, and she had said his own book back to him in one line, and she had not done it to score.

“Yes,” he said. “That is what I am asking you to do.”

“I know,” she said. “I know exactly what you’re asking me to do. I’ve been trying to work out how to do it since six o’clock this morning.”

That is the thing about her that I could never make anybody understand afterwards, particularly the journalists.

She had got in early and read it twice and tried to find a way.

“What do you need,” I said, “to open it?”

“A body,” she said. “Give me one identified deceased with a linkable circumstance and I can open a series and I can go to the province for a team. Or give me two dockets in the same district with the same broker on both. Two. Not nine absences — two *dockets*.”

“Nobody will take the reports.”

“Then I will make somebody take the reports,” she said, and pulled a pad over. “That I can do without asking anybody. That costs me nothing and it is *already the instruction*, so nobody can tell me no.”

She wrote for a while.

“Bring the mothers,” she said. “Not the files. The mothers. Any of them who will come. Get them to De Doorns station on a day I nominate and I will phone that station commander myself the day before and tell him that a colonel from provincial is interested in his fifty-five A’s. You’ll get your dockets. And the moment there are two in

one district with a common denominator, I have got a reason, and I don't have to ask anybody for permission to have a reason."

I wrote that down so fast I tore the page.

At the door Piet stopped and said, "Colonel. May I ask a question that is not about this."

"Go on."

"Why do you believe me?"

Nyathi looked at him for a long moment.

"Because in twenty-six years," she said, "I have never once had someone come in here and give me a number of victims that was *lower* than the one they actually believed."

Piet did not answer that.

"It's on your face," she said. "It's on both your faces. You've got a bigger number. You've left it at home because you thought I'd throw you out." She capped her pen. "I'm not going to ask you what it is, because if you tell me it, I will have to write it down, and then it is a thing on a page in my office that I cannot act on. So keep it. But don't do me the discourtesy of thinking I can't count."

In the corridor Piet said, "She is better than I expected."

"She's better than anybody I worked for in fourteen years."

"Yes," he said, and then, after a moment: "That is worse."

"How is that worse?"

And he stopped in the middle of the corridor with the lift doors open in front of him and said:

"Because I had a version of this in my head in which the reason nothing happens is that the people in these buildings are lazy or corrupt or stupid, and that version is a comfort, Adonis, because in that version you fix it by replacing them." He watched the doors close on nothing. "She is not lazy. She is not corrupt. She is not stupid. She got in at six and read it twice and she is going to bend every rule

she has to help us, and it is *still* going to take us four months and a private helicopter, because there are nine columns on that board and four vehicles that go.”

He pressed the button again.

“There is nobody to replace,” he said. “That is the part I did not want to know.”

Chapter 10

We took the mothers to De Doorns station on a Thursday.

Six of them, in the end. Aunty Miems and Bernadine Klaasen's sister Charmaine — another Charmaine, which caused about four minutes of confusion and one small piece of laughter that everybody needed — and Amoret Booysen's mother from Touwsrivier, and Neliswa Mgcini's aunt who had come up on a bus from Mthatha over two days and would not be talked into being tired, and Sylvia Tafira's mother, and a woman called Grieta whose daughter was not on our list at all and who is the reason for the last half of this chapter.

I picked up three of them myself. Piet drove the other two, and when I say Piet drove them I mean that Piet drove for two hours and forty minutes in a car with two strangers in it, which is a sentence I want the record to reflect, because he did it without discussion, and he was not able to speak for the rest of that day, and he did it again the following week.

Nyathi had phoned the station commander on the Wednesday. I don't know what she said. I know that when we came through the door at ten to nine there was a woman constable at the counter who had clearly been told, and a table pulled into the corner of the CSC with four chairs around it, and a folder of blank fifty-five A's already on it, squared up.

That's all it took. One phone call from a colonel who was interested.

Aunty Miems went first because the others made her.

I sat next to her. Not to speak — she didn't need me to speak. To

be a person sitting next to her, which is a thing that has weight in a police station and has no name.

It took thirty-eight minutes.

Thirty-eight minutes. Name. ID number. Date of birth. Height, build, complexion, distinguishing marks, and Auntie Miems said, "Sy het 'n litteken hier," and touched her own eyebrow, and the constable wrote *scar, above left eye, approx 2cm*, and I had to look at the ceiling for a second because in eight months nobody had ever asked that woman what her daughter looked like.

Last seen wearing. Last contact and how. Persons who may have information. Photograph — Miems had brought four, and the constable took the clearest one and photocopied it and stapled the copy and gave the original back, and Auntie Miems said, "Kan ek dit hou?" and the constable said, "Dis joune, Mevrouw," and that is a small thing and it is not a small thing.

Then a case number.

Then the constable wrote her own name and her cell number on the top of a photocopy and said, "As jy iets hoor, of as jy net wil weet, bel my. Nie die stasie nie. My."

Thirty-eight minutes.

That is what did not happen on the fourth of January, and on the thirtieth of January, and in the middle of March.

Auntie Miems came and sat down next to me on the bench with the case number in her hand on a piece of paper, and she looked at it, and she said, "Dis al?"

That's all?

And I said, "Ja, Auntie. Dis al."

And she started crying then, properly, for the first time in front of me, in a police station, at half past nine in the morning, holding a case number — not because her daughter was dead, she had known that since Christmas — but because it had taken thirty-eight minutes, and she had waited eight months, and both of those things were true at once and there was nowhere to put them.

Six mothers. Five dockets by two in the afternoon.

The sixth was Neliswa Mgcini's aunt, and hers could not be taken at De Doorns because Neliswa was last seen in Kakamas, and the constable phoned Kakamas, and Kakamas said bring her here, and the aunt who had been on a bus for two days said, "Ek sal gaan," and Piet stood up and said, "I will drive you," and I said, "Piet," and he said, "It is four hours," in the tone of a man correcting a factual error, and they went, and he phoned me from Upington at nine that night and said one sentence — "It is taken" — and put the phone down.

He would not go into Upington town. He slept in the car outside a Wimpy on the N14 and drove back at four in the morning.

I did not know that until much later. He told me on a different road, in a different month, and I will put it where it belongs.

Grieta was standing in the parking area at half past eleven with a plastic sleeve of documents.

Nobody had brought her. She had heard from her cousin's neighbour that people were at the station today about the women who don't come back, and she had walked from the top of the town.

Her daughter's name was Rochelle and she had gone in April two years ago for the last of the grapes and had not come home, and she had reported it — she had reported it, straight away, at the same station, and been told to come back in a week, and she had come back in a week and been told the detective was on leave, and she had come back after that and been told they were looking.

She had a case number. She had had a case number for two years.

I want to be precise about what that meant, because I got it wrong in the moment and Piet had to explain it to me at eleven o'clock that night, and I was too tired and too proud to hear it properly the first time.

I thought: good. A docket. That's what Nyathi asked for.

What it actually meant was this. Rochelle's disappearance had been *inside the system for two years*. It had a number. It had, technically,

an investigating officer. And it had produced exactly as much as Decline Fortuin's non-existent docket had produced, which was nothing at all — and it had done so *silently*, which is worse, because for two years Grieta had believed that somewhere a process was running.

The absence of a docket is a wound you can see. A docket that does nothing looks identical to a docket that is working, from the outside, for years.

"So it's not the reporting," I said, that night, on the phone.

"No," said Piet. "The reporting is the first wall. There are four."

By the following Wednesday we had eleven.

That is the part nobody expected, including me, and it did not come from Facebook or from the maroon file or from any clever thing.

It came from the mothers.

They talked to each other in the parking area and on the pavement and in my car on the way home, and then they talked to their sisters, and their sisters talked at church, and one of them — Amoret's mother — put a thing on Facebook that was not a post about her own daughter but a post that said: *if your child went for work and did not come back, phone this number, they will help you make the case.*

And she put my number on it.

Two hundred and six calls in nine days.

Most of them were not ours. I want to be very clear about that, because when the number started moving there were people who accused us of collecting anything with a pulse. Most of them were a brother in Gauteng who has not phoned since 2011. Most of them were somebody's ex who moved to Kimberley. Most of them were the ordinary sorrow of a country where people leave and do not always say why.

But two of them were ours.

And in every single one of the two hundred and six, without exception, there was a woman on the other end of a phone who had needed, at some point, to tell somebody, and had not had anybody to tell.

I did not sleep much that week either.

Nyathi phoned on the Friday.

“Adonis. Two dockets, same district, common denominator.”

“Colonel—”

“De Doorns has four now. Four in one district. And I’ve got the Springbok one on my desk.” A pause, and I could hear paper. “I’ve opened a series. Provincial reference. It’s mine.”

I stood up in the middle of the office.

“What does that give us?”

“It gives me a reason to ask people things,” she said. “That’s all it gives us. Don’t get excited. But now when I phone Northern Cape I’m not a colonel with a hobby, I’m a colonel with a series.”

“Thank you.”

“Don’t thank me.” Paper again. “Adonis — there’s an unidentified female in the Salt River system that’s been sitting since March last year. Found off the R355. It came up when I ran the circumstances. It is almost certainly nothing to do with you.”

“But.”

“But nobody has ever gone and looked at it,” said Nyathi, “and I do not have a vehicle until the eleventh, and Dr Mtimkulu will see anybody who asks. So ask.”

Chapter 11

Dr Elsie Mtimkulu gave us her lunch hour and ate a sandwich through most of it, and I have never in my life met anybody less interested in being careful with me.

“You want the R355 one,” she said. “Sit. Don’t sit there, that’s wet.”

Her office was a room made entirely of paper and one window. There was a plant on the sill that was doing better than any of us. On the wall behind her desk, floor to about shoulder height, there were lists.

Piet looked at them for about four seconds and then looked at the floor and did not look up again for the rest of the meeting, and I do not think Elsie Mtimkulu noticed, and I do not think it would have changed anything if she had.

“March last year,” she said. “Female. Found by a farmer’s son off the R355 about forty kilometres from the Ceres side. She’d been there a while. Skeletonised, mostly. No clothing recovered that helps. No jewellery. Two healed fractures, one old — childhood — one about four to six years before death, left ulna. Dental work: two fillings, one extraction, and the extraction is the interesting one because it’s the kind you get at a clinic, not at a dentist.”

“Cause of death?”

“Undetermined.” She put the sandwich down. “And before you look at me like that — undetermined does not mean I didn’t look. It means she was outside for eleven months and I am not going to write a cause on a form so that somebody in a court can take it apart in four minutes and make everything else I said unreliable. She has

no soft tissue. There is no fracture pattern that carries a story. So: undetermined, and I am not embarrassed about it.”

“And the ID?”

“There is no ID.”

“Is there DNA?”

“There is a sample,” said Elsie. “There has been a sample since the eighth of April last year.”

She let that sit.

“And?” I said.

“And a sample is not a search,” she said. “You have to have something to search *against*.”

Here is where I found out what I actually did not know, after fourteen years in the service, and I am putting it in because I would bet my pension that most people reading this don’t know it either.

“There’s a national DNA database,” said Elsie. “It works. It’s real. It is not a fiction and it is not broken, and I get very tired of people saying it’s broken, because the people who work on it are drowning and they don’t need me adding to it.”

“Then—”

“It is built for crime. It is built to match a sample from a scene to an offender, or an offender to a scene. That is what it was legislated for, that is what it is resourced for, and at that it works.” She turned her chair slightly. “There is also a capability for familial searching. You take a sample from a mother and you look for a partial match — because a mother and a daughter share half. It exists. It is not theoretical. It has been demonstrated, in this country, in published work, on our own database.”

“So we take Auntie Miems’s blood.”

“You take a buccal swab, it’s a cotton bud, it takes four seconds and it doesn’t hurt.” Elsie folded her hands. “And then nothing happens. Because there is no standing programme that takes swabs from the families of missing persons and runs them against the unidentified

dead. The capability exists. The database exists. The families exist — they will queue, Adonis, they will queue around the block, they have been trying to give somebody a piece of themselves for years. The dead exist; I have four hundred and some of them in a book in this room.”

“So what’s missing?”

“Someone whose job it is,” she said.

She had a folder. She had had it for a long time; you could see that from the corners.

“Nineteen years,” she said. “Four administrations. Every two years I send the same document. It is now nineteen pages because I keep adding the new figures and I have never once had to change the argument.”

“What do they say back?”

“They say it’s a good document.” She said it entirely without bitterness, which was somehow worse. “It is a good document. It has never been the document.”

Piet spoke for the first time.

“How many,” he said, to the floor.

“How many what, Mr Buys? Be precise with me and I’ll be precise with you.”

“How many people were buried in this province last year without a name.”

“Two hundred and eighty-nine,” said Elsie. “Two hundred and seventy-nine of those in the metro.”

“Nationally?”

“I don’t know.”

“You must have—”

“I have a number I have seen written down,” she said, “and I am not going to say it to you, because I cannot source it, and the moment I say a number I cannot source, everything else I have told you today

becomes an opinion.” She tapped the folder. “You will find people who will tell you ten thousand a year. You will find a figure of about three thousand for bodies currently lying unclaimed in state mortuaries. Those two numbers are not the same kind of thing and putting them next to each other is how you get a headline and no policy. I have watched it happen three times.”

I wrote *289 / 279 metro* in my book and underlined it twice, and I have used those two numbers, and only those two numbers, in every interview I have given since.

“After thirty days,” Elsie said, “I may release for a pauper burial. May. Not must. I hold them longer than that, when I can, and ‘when I can’ means when there is space, and there is not always space, and I want you to understand that I am the one who decides, and that I decide on the basis of a fridge.”

She looked at the wall of lists.

“They go into the ground with a number,” she said. “There is a plot, and there is a record, and if you come to me in eleven years with a name I can tell you exactly where she is. People think they disappear. They don’t. Everything about them is written down. That is what nobody understands about this.”

And that is where the title of this whole thing came from, in a room with one window at ten past one in the afternoon.

Because I said — and I said it badly, and I meant it kindly, and it was the wrong thing —

“So they’re just... unidentified. Nameless.”

And Elsie Mtimkulu looked at me the way a person looks at somebody who has been very slightly rude about their family.

“No,” she said. “Every one of them has a name. Somebody knows it. Somebody is saying it out loud today.” She put a hand flat on the folder. “And every one of them has a number. She has a DR number, she has a case number, she has a plot number and a page in a book. She is one of the most thoroughly *numbered* people in this country.”

“Then what—”

"She is not *counted*," said Elsie.

"I don't—"

"There is no total, Adonis." She said it slowly, because she could see I hadn't got it, and she wanted me to get it, and I have been grateful to her ever since. "There is no figure, anywhere, that anybody has to stand up and answer for. There is no line on any budget, no target, no annual report where somebody has to say: this year, this many women went for work and did not arrive, and here is what we did about it. Nobody adds them up. Not because they're hiding it — because nobody was ever given the job of adding it up."

She picked her sandwich back up.

"That's your book of the dead," she said. "It's not a book of people without names. It's a book of people who were never in anybody's arithmetic. You can be numbered a dozen ways and never once be counted."

Outside, in the car park, Piet stood with his hand on the roof of the car and did not open the door for about two minutes, and I let him.

Then he said, "I want the swabs."

"Elsie can't run them."

"I know she cannot run them. I want them taken anyway." He got in. "Six mothers. Buccal swabs, consented, witnessed, stored properly, with a chain of custody that would survive a magistrate. Held privately."

"By who? We can't hold—"

"Hendrik can hold them," said Piet.

And he said it looking straight out of the windscreen at a wall, in the flat voice, and I sat there with my hand on the ignition and did not start the car, because in three years and four months I had heard him say his brother's name exactly twice.

Chapter 12

Vantage Security Group has its head office in a building in Century City with a water feature in front of it and a lobby you could land a helicopter in, and I mention the helicopter because we will get to the helicopter.

Hendrik Buys came down to fetch us himself. That is a thing about him I want to put in before anything else, because it is easy to write him as a type and he is not a type. The CEO of a listed company came down eleven floors to the lobby to fetch his brother, and put his arm around him, and Piet let him, and I nearly dropped my bag.

“Pietie.”

“Hendrik.”

“You’ve lost weight. Is he eating?” — this to me, over Piet’s shoulder, cheerfully, in the tone of a man who has asked it before.

“Sometimes,” I said.

“Sometimes.” He laughed. He has a good laugh; that is the problem with him. “You must be Adonis. He speaks about you.”

“Does he.”

“He said you were the only person he’s ever worked with who doesn’t fill the silence.” He said it like a compliment and it was one, and I have thought since about the fact that Piet had never said it to me and had said it to his brother.

The office had a view of the mountain on one side and, on the other, on a screen that took up most of a wall, a map of the Western Cape

with about eleven hundred moving dots on it.

Every dot was a vehicle. Every vehicle was a response unit. There was a panel down the side of the screen with numbers going up and down and one of them said, in green, *AVG RESP 04:11*.

Four minutes eleven. So it wasn't a lie after all. Not from here.

I stood in front of that screen for a while, and Hendrik came and stood next to me and did not say anything, and I want to be fair and record that he did not say anything, because a lesser man would have.

Then I said, "How many members?"

"Eleven thousand four hundred, give or take. Armed response, guarding, cash services, monitoring." He put his hands in his pockets. "We're the fourth biggest."

"Fourth."

"There are three bigger."

"And the police in this province have how many?"

"Fewer," said Hendrik Buys, "and I'd rather they had more, and that is not a line I do for journalists, it is what I actually think. Nothing about my business is good news, Ms Adonis. It's just that it's a business, and if it isn't me it's somebody worse."

I have turned that sentence over many times. It is completely true and it is completely useless and I could not then and cannot now find the flaw in it.

Piet did the asking, which surprised me, and did it standing up, which surprised me more.

He wanted three things.

One: cold storage and chain of custody for six buccal swabs, taken with consent, held in a manner that would survive a magistrate.

Two: access to Vantage's vehicle-tracking archive for the N7 and R355 corridors — not live, historic — because Vantage does route risk for logistics clients and holds four years of it.

Three: fuel-card transaction data for a set of registration numbers he would supply.

Hendrik listened all the way through without interrupting, which runs in the family.

Then he said, "One and two, today. Three is not mine to give, but I know the man, and he owes me, and he will give it to me and he will not ask why."

"Hendrik—"

"You want me to say no first?" He smiled. "I'm not going to make you ask twice, Pietie. You've asked once in eleven years. I'm not going to make it expensive."

Then he took us to lunch, and Piet did not eat, and the thing happened.

It was not a fight. Nobody raised anything. It was worse than a fight. It was two men who love each other having the same conversation they have had for a decade, in a restaurant, quietly, in front of a witness.

Hendrik said the thing about the schools first. Vantage does forty-one schools in the metro for nothing. That's real, I checked it afterwards, it's audited and it's in the annual report and it is about eleven million rand a year of guarding that nobody pays for.

And Piet said, "I know. You have told me. It is a good thing and I have never said it is not a good thing."

"Then what?"

"You do forty-one schools for nothing," said Piet, "out of a business whose revenue rises when the country gets worse. If policing worked, your share price would halve in a year. You know that. Your investors know it. It is in your own risk register — I have read it, it is a public document, it says *material improvement in state policing capability* under downside risks."

Hendrik put his knife down.

"Yes," he said. "It does."

"So when you give me the tracking archive today, in an afternoon, faster than the State can give Colonel Nyathi a vehicle before the eleventh — you are not helping me in spite of your business. You are demonstrating it." Piet was looking at the tablecloth. "You are the proof of the thing that killed these women. And you are also the only reason I am going to find him. Both. At the same time. And I do not know what to do with that, Hendrik, I have never known what to do with it, and it is not an accusation, it is that I genuinely do not know what to do with it."

There was a long silence.

Then Hendrik said, quietly: "Neither do I."

And that is why I could never hate him, and I tried.

There was one other thing at that lunch, and it lasted about eleven seconds, and I did not write it down at the time because it did not seem to be about anything.

Hendrik's phone went face-up on the table and he glanced at it and made a small noise.

"Sorry. Bid team."

"Bid?"

"We're in for a state contract. Perimeter and monitoring for a department, national. Biggest thing we'd ever have done." He turned the phone over. "Anyway. Two years of paper. It'll come to nothing."

And we went back to the salt.

In the lift going down Piet said, "I should not have said the thing about the risk register."

"You should have said it years ago."

"I said it at a lunch six years ago, with our mother there, and I was not careful, and I have not been invited to a family lunch since." He watched the numbers. "Today I was careful. It cost the same."

"He said neither do I, Piet."

“Yes.”

“That’s not nothing.”

“No,” said Piet. “It is the most honest thing anybody has said to me since this began, including you and including me.”

The doors opened onto the lobby with the water feature.

“He will send the swab kits this afternoon,” he said. “They will be better than the ones the State would use. They will arrive in a marked vehicle within four minutes of being dispatched. Write that down, Adonis, and put it in whatever you are writing, because one day somebody is going to ask you what was actually wrong with this country, and that is the whole answer and it takes one line.”

Chapter 13

The tracking archive arrived at 15:52 that afternoon.

Ninety-one minutes from a man saying yes in a restaurant to four years of vehicle movement data sitting on a hard drive on a desk above a bicycle shop in Stellenbosch, delivered by a courier in a marked vehicle, signed for, with a compliance letter attached explaining the lawful basis on which it was being shared with a contracted risk consultant, which we now apparently were.

Colonel Thandeka Nyathi, of the South African Police Service, had a vehicle available on the eleventh.

I have never got over that. I don't think I'm supposed to.

The swabs took two days and they were the best two days of that whole year, and I did not expect that and neither did Piet.

Here is what I thought it would be: six grieving women being asked to give up a piece of their own body so that a machine could tell them their daughter was dead.

Here is what it was.

Aunty Miems sat at her own kitchen table with the cloth on it and the biscuits out, and I explained it, and Piet stood by the door because a kitchen with a stranger doing a procedure in it needs one fewer man in the middle of it than you think. I said: this is a cotton bud. I rub it inside your cheek for four seconds. It doesn't hurt, it doesn't take blood, and it can't be used for anything except comparing to Deline.

And I said the hard part, because I had promised myself I would say

the hard part every single time and never soften it: *this may never be run. There is no programme. There is no queue we're joining. We are keeping these so that on the day somebody is willing to run them, we do not have to come back to you and ask.*

Aunty Miems said, "Gee hier."

She opened her mouth like a woman at a dentist and I did four seconds inside her cheek and put the bud in the tube and sealed it and she signed the form and Piet witnessed it and dated it.

And then she sat back and said, "So nou is ek in die ding."

Now I'm in the thing.

That's it. That is what it was. Not grief. *Participation.* For eight months she had been a woman who phoned people. Now there was a tube with her name on it in a fridge and it could not be taken away from her, and when the day came — if the day came — she had already done her part and done it first.

Five out of six of them said some version of the same sentence. Grieta, who was not on our list and whose daughter had had a case number for two years, held the tube afterwards and looked at it for a while and said, "Dis meer as wat hulle in twee jaar gedoen het."

That's more than they did in two years.

It cost eleven rand and it took four seconds.

We had, by the end of that week, in a private office above a bicycle shop, the following.

Six DNA samples with consent forms, witnessed, dated, in a validated cold chain in a facility in Century City owned by a listed company.

Four years of vehicle movement across two corridors.

Fuel-card transaction histories for fourteen registration numbers.

Eleven women, five new dockets, one provincial series reference, and a colonel who read her email.

And the State of the Republic of South Africa had: a series reference, and a vehicle available on the eleventh.

I sat on the floor of the office on the Friday night after everybody had gone home and had a small, private, entirely unproductive crisis about it.

Because I had spent fourteen years inside that state. I had done the FCS course. I had sat in a room in 2006 and been told my unit was being decentralised and had watched every specialist I knew get sent to a station to do house robberies, and I had sat in another room in 2010 and been told we were being re-established, and had done four more years of it with two vehicles for eleven detectives. And the whole time I believed — I actually believed — that the problem was money and that if the money came the thing would work.

The money came. It went to Century City. It bought eleven thousand four hundred members and a screen with eleven hundred dots on it and an average response of four minutes eleven, and it is *very good*, and it does not attend to Deline Fortuin, because Deline Fortuin never had a contract.

That's not corruption. Nobody stole it. It was never in the state's hands to steal. It went straight past.

Piet came back at about nine and found me on the floor and did not ask what was wrong, which is his best quality.

He sat down against the other desk with the hard drive in his lap.

"Four years," he said.

"Ja."

"Every vehicle that his client base insured, every route, four years, timestamped to the second." He was turning it over in his hands. "There is a very good chance that the answer to all of this is on here, and has been on here for four years, and that nobody has ever had a reason to look."

"Is that supposed to make me feel better?"

"No," he said. "I have been sitting in a car park for forty minutes trying to decide whether to say it to you at all."

"Say it."

"If we find him with this," said Piet, "then the reason he was not found before is not that it was impossible. It is that the data was privately owned and the question was never asked by anybody who could pay for it." He looked up. "Which means that the difference between eleven women and none was a *purchase order*. Not a genius. Not a breakthrough. An invoice."

I put my head back against the desk.

"He's going to be so ordinary," I said. "Isn't he?"

"Yes," said Piet. "I have never had any doubt about that."

I asked him, that night, the thing I had been circling since the lobby with the water feature.

"Why haven't you asked him before? Eleven years, Piet. He'd have given you anything."

And he thought about it long enough that I knew the answer was going to be an honest one.

"Because he would have given me anything," he said.

"That's not—"

"It is exactly the reason." He set the drive down. "If I can have it any time I want it, then every case I do not solve becomes a case in which I chose not to ask my brother. And every case I do solve, I have solved by being the man whose brother owns eleven thousand four hundred members." He turned his hands over and looked at them, which he does. "Adonis, I am the profiler who could not stay in a unit and cannot get through a Saturday in a shopping centre. The one thing I have is that what I do, I do out of what is publicly available and what is in my head. If I take the helicopter every time, then in eleven years I will be a man who phones his brother."

"You'd have found them faster."

"Yes."

"Some of them might—"

"Yes," said Piet. "I have thought about that every day since the fourteenth of March three years ago, and I will be thinking about it on the

day I die, and I would like now to talk about something else, please.”

So we talked about something else.

But I want it in the account, because two months later, in a different province, a version of that exact reasoning is going to get a man beaten half to death in a street in Springbok, and when it happens people are going to ask me whether there were any warnings.

There were. There was this one. He told me himself, on a floor, on a Friday night, in his own words: *the one thing I have is what is in my head.*

You cannot audit what is in a man’s head. That’s the whole problem. And he had been alone in there with a pencil for three years and four months.

Chapter 14

The reconstruction took four days and I was there for about eleven hours of it.

I want to be honest about that, because in the version that got told afterwards we did it together, and we did not. I had eleven mothers to phone and a business to keep alive and a child doing her prelims. I did the phones. He did the floor.

What follows I have partly from being there and partly from the state of the room, which by the Wednesday was legible to me the way a scene is legible.

Monday. He printed the tracking archive.

Not all of it — you cannot print four years of vehicle movement, it is a hundred and some gigabytes and it is mostly nothing. He wrote something to pull it apart, badly, in a language he half knows, and then rewrote it, and then rewrote it again on the Tuesday when he found that he had been excluding the wrong end of the date ranges. He told me about the error unprompted, at length, twice, and made me initial a note about it in the file, which is a thing he does that I did not understand for two years and now understand completely: he is building a record of his own mistakes because he does not trust himself to remember them in the right proportion.

What he printed was the shoulders. Both windows, four years. Eight windows, nine days each.

Seventy-two days out of one thousand four hundred and sixty.

“Because if he only exists in the shoulder,” he said, “then everything

outside the shoulder is a distraction, and I have three years of experience of being distracted.”

Tuesday. He laid it out.

By Tuesday night there were four hundred and eleven pages on the floor and up the wall and along the skirting board, and the corridor outside had started, and Riaan came up at about seven with two plates of food from the takeaway on the corner and put them down inside the door and did not come in, because he had looked at the floor and understood, without a word from anybody, that the floor was not to be walked on.

He did that every night for four nights. He never once asked what it was. When it was over, and it was in the newspapers, he still never asked.

Wednesday. The bad day.

I came in at eight and Piet was standing in the middle of the room with a page in each hand and I said good morning and he did not answer, and I said his name, and he did not answer, and I stopped in the doorway.

He was not ill. He was not having what people who have never seen one call an episode. He was at the far end of the thing where the language has gone and the work has not — where he can still see the whole floor and hold every page in it at once and cannot produce a sentence to save his life. It lasts a few hours. It has happened maybe nine times in three years and every time it has been on day three of something.

So I did what we do. I put water where he would walk into it. I opened the window. I turned off the overhead light and put the desk lamp on, and I texted him — from four metres away, in the same room, which looks insane and is the single most useful thing I have ever learned about him — *I'm here. I'm going to do phones downstairs. Text me a number when you want food.*

He texted me a number at half past one. The number was 4, which meant four o'clock, which meant he had decided he could not eat until he had finished a thing and had negotiated with himself about it.

At four I brought him food and he ate all of it and said, "Thank you. I am sorry. I could not."

"I know."

"It is not distress."

"I know, Piet."

"People think it is distress. It is—" He put his hand flat on the table, which is the tell. "It is that there is no line free."

Thursday. He found it.

I need to explain what he was actually doing, because it is the thing this whole book is about, and if I let it stay mysterious I am doing exactly what the films do.

He was not looking for a murderer. There is no murderer in vehicle-tracking data.

He was looking for **a vehicle that moved when no work was happening.**

That is it. That is the entire method, and he had it on the Monday and spent four days proving that he could do it.

Because the crews move. That's the whole economy: bakkies full of people going up to the citrus in October, back down for the grapes in December, out to the packhouses in March. In the shoulder, when one thing has ended and the next hasn't started, the roads are *quiet*. Not empty. Quiet. The logistics still run and the trucks still run and the tourists still go to the flowers in Namaqualand.

But the labour vehicles stop. For six to nine days, twice a year, the specific traffic of people being carried to work stops, because there is no work.

"So I do not need to know which vehicle is his," Piet said, on the Thursday, sitting on the floor with his back to the desk and a cup going cold beside him. "I need to know which vehicle *does not stop*."

There were nineteen.

Nineteen registrations that appeared on those corridors, in those seventy-two days, across four years, more than twice.

Eleven of them fell out immediately: they were logistics, they were a courier, one was a mobile clinic, one was a man who evidently visits his mother in Springbok with great regularity and I hope he never learns that he was on a list on a floor in Stellenbosch.

Six more went on the Thursday afternoon when he cross-matched them against the fuel-card data, which he had had since Tuesday and had deliberately not opened, because — and he explained this to me carefully, twice, and made me initial it — *“if I open the fuel data first I will find a vehicle I like and then I will look for the movement that fits it.”*

Which is, and I did not know this then, the most important sentence anybody says in this entire account.

Two left.

One was a white Toyota Hilux single cab registered to A. Damon of De Doorns, which is the broker's own bakkie, and which of course moves in the shoulder, because a broker in the shoulder is driving around assembling next season's crews, which is his entire job.

And one was a Nissan NP300, white, registered to a labour contracting business in Vredendal that had been deregistered two years earlier and had not stopped buying diesel.

Piet put those two pages side by side on the floor at twenty past four on the Thursday afternoon.

Then he sat and looked at them until it was dark, and did not turn the light on.

Chapter 15

Kaap-Wes Arbeid en Vervoer BK was deregistered by the Companies Commission two years ago for failure to file returns, which is the least sinister thing that can happen to a business in this country and happens to about a hundred thousand of them a year.

It had one vehicle. A white Nissan NP300, 2016, and the licence was current, and the diesel kept being bought — three, four, five hundred rand at a time, at Vredendal, at Klawer, at Garies, at Springbok, at Kakamas — on a fleet card that had never been cancelled because nobody cancels anything when a business quietly stops existing.

“That is not suspicious either,” said Piet, on the Friday morning, before I could say it. “That is the most ordinary thing on the entire floor. Half the vehicles on the West Coast belong to a company that does not exist.”

“Then why—”

“Because it is the only one of the nineteen that moves in the shoulder, does not carry a crew, and belongs to nobody.”

The member listed for the close corporation, at deregistration, was a man called Fanie Loubser, of Vredendal, who had died in 2021.

That took us most of a Friday to establish and about four minutes to understand, once we had it: the member is dead, the CC is deregistered, the vehicle’s licence is renewed every year by somebody, and the fuel card is settled every month from an account nobody has looked at in four years.

The vehicle is a ghost with a full tank.

"Somebody is paying for that diesel," I said.

"Somebody is paying about eleven hundred rand a month for that diesel," said Piet, "and has been for four years, and if we can find out who, we are finished."

We could not find out who. Not then. That took until Movement — sorry. That took until October, and it took a subpoena, and it is the last chapter of this story, and I am not going to put it here just because I know it.

What we could find out was who *drove* it.

And here is where I have to slow down and be very careful, because this is the part where we were right, and then went wrong, and the going wrong did not feel like going wrong. It felt like Thursday becoming Friday.

We were **right about the vehicle**. Everything that happened afterwards, every single thing, including the arrest, came out of a white NP300 that moved when nothing was moving. Piet Buys found that in four days off a hard drive a listed company gave him for free and the finding was correct.

We were **wrong about the man**, and the reason we were wrong is in the next fifty pages, and I want the reader to know now, at the top, that it was not a piece of stupidity. It was not carelessness. It was, in fact, the exact same instrument that got the vehicle, pointed at a person.

His name was Neville Arendse. Forty-six. Vredendal.

We got him from Ashwin Damon, who I phoned on the Friday afternoon and who answered on the second ring and said "Mevrou Adonis!" like I was a cousin.

"Ashwin, a white NP300. Nissan. Kaap-Wes Arbeid."

"Ja."

"Ja?"

"Ja, ek ken die bakkie."

I sat down slowly. "Whose is it?"

"Ek weet nie wie s'n dit is nie. Fanie s'n was dit, Fanie's dood." A pause; I could hear him walking. "Nevie ry hom."

"Nevie."

"Neville. Neville Arendse. Hy ry vir enigeen. Hy's 'n drywer, hy't nie 'n eie bakkie nie, hy vat werk waar dit kom."

He drives for anyone. He's a driver, he doesn't have his own bakkie, he takes work where it comes.

"Does he drive for you?"

"Party keer. As ek twee loads het."

"Ashwin, was he driving in October? Crew four?"

And Ashwin Damon said, "Ek weet nie," in exactly the tone with which he had told me, three weeks earlier, that he does not count heads on the road back, and I put the phone down and sat looking at my own hands for a while.

Neville Arendse had a criminal record.

One entry. Two thousand and nine. Assault with intent, six months suspended, and when I pulled what I could get of the circumstances it was a domestic matter with his then-partner and the file was thin and old and told you almost nothing, the way they do.

I put it on Piet's desk on the Monday morning and I said, out loud, in the room, because I want it in this account that I did say it:

"Piet, that's a fifteen-year-old suspended sentence for a domestic and half the men in this country have one."

"Yes," he said.

"So it's not evidence."

"No," he said. "It is not evidence."

And he was completely right and completely sincere and he meant it entirely, and I watched him put the page down on the left-hand side of the desk, which is the side where the things go that are about

Neville Arendse, and the left-hand side of that desk stayed there for six weeks and got thicker, and the right-hand side, which was where everything else went, did not.

That's how it happens. It is not a decision. Nobody decides. A pile gets thicker on one side of a desk and a man who cannot leave a noticed thing alone has been given something to notice.

We had, at that point, and I have laid it out on a page like this many times since:

A vehicle that moves in the shoulder and belongs to nobody. **True. Load-bearing. Correct.**

A driver who drives that vehicle, among many vehicles, for many people. **True. Neutral.**

A driver with a fifteen-year-old suspended sentence. **True. Meaningless.**

A driver who was in the district in October. **True of approximately four hundred men.**

Four true things. Not one of them was wrong. And you can build a house out of four true things and have it be the wrong house, and there is no moment in the building of it where somebody hands you a brick that is false.

I have thought about how to say this properly for two years and this is the best I have got:

He did not make anything up. He never has. The failure was not a false fact.

The failure was that he was the only person in the room, and he had been the only person in the room for three years and four months, and by the time I was standing next to him I had already started agreeing with him — because he had been right about the Tuesdays, and right about the shoulder, and right about the ghost bakkie, and after enough of that you stop auditing and start following.

I stopped auditing somewhere around the tenth of that month.

Nobody told me to. Nobody asked me to. I did it on my own, because

it is *easier*, and because being the person who says *or she just liked those shoes* to a man who is right nine times out of ten makes you feel like the stupidest person in the building nine times out of ten.

And the tenth time is a man in a street in Springbok.

Chapter 16

The fuel card went north.

That is the whole of this chapter and I could stop there, but the going north is the part where this stopped being a case and became the eleven weeks that took my back out again and cost me my daughter's prelim results evening, so I am going to do it properly.

Four years of diesel. Every shoulder window, the same shape: Vredendal, Klawer, Garies, Springbok. And then, in five of the eight windows, one more transaction past Springbok — **Steinkopf**, which is the last place you can buy diesel in the Republic, sixty-seven kilometres short of the line.

That on its own means nothing. Somebody filling up at Steinkopf is a man going to Steinkopf.

It was Piet who saw the other thing, and he saw it at about half past eleven at night, and he did not phone me, he waited until the morning, which for him is a kind of restraint I did not know he had.

In two of the eight windows, the next transaction on that card — the very next one, forty minutes later — is at **Noordoewer**.

I had to look it up. I am South African and I have lived here my whole life and I had to look up where Noordoewer is.

It is on the other side.

There is no filling station at Vioolsdrif. There has never been one. You come up the N7 through the Richtersveld and the last pump in this country is at Steinkopf, and then there is nothing, and then there is a bridge over the Orange River, and on the far side of that bridge

the road stops being the N7 and becomes the B1, and about four kilometres in there is a garage.

So a fleet card belonging to a close corporation that was deregistered two years ago, on a bakkie registered to a man who died in 2021, bought diesel in the Republic of Namibia. Twice. In the shoulder. Forty minutes after Steinkopf.

Nobody in this book ever had to say the word *border*. The card said it.

I took it to Nyathi on the Tuesday, and she did the thing I already knew she was going to do, and she did it kindly.

“I can’t.”

“Colonel—”

“Adonis, listen to me properly, because I want you to be able to explain this to those mothers and I don’t want you explaining it wrong.” She had the page in front of her. “My series is Western Cape. I have a colleague in Northern Cape who has taken my call twice and been decent both times, and if I send him this he will read it, and he will believe it, and he will put it on a pile with his own nine columns on it. That is not obstruction. That’s Tuesday.”

“And the border?”

“The border is not police work. The border is a mutual legal assistance request, which is Justice, not SAPS, and which goes to a national office, and which takes—” she stopped. “I was going to say months.”

“How long, Colonel?”

“I have been waiting two years and four months on one,” she said, “for a matter in which we have a body, a suspect, and a confession.”

So that was that.

I want to be clear that Nyathi did not throw us out and did not tell us not to go. What she did was lean back and look at the ceiling for

a while and then say a sentence very carefully, in the manner of a woman placing something on a table without touching it.

“There is nothing in law,” she said, “that prevents a member of the public from travelling to another country and asking members of the public in that country questions.”

“No, Colonel.”

“And if a member of the public happened to obtain, lawfully, from a member of the public, information which they then handed to me—”

“That would just be a person giving information to the police.”

“That is exactly what that would be,” said Nyathi. “That happens forty times a day in this building.”

She sat forward.

“Now. Here is the other half, and this is not the fun half. If you go up there and you do this badly, you will burn it. Not for you — for me. If a Namibian officer’s first contact with this matter is two South Africans arriving without notice and asking about a dead woman, then when I eventually get my request through, in two years, the file will already have a note on it saying two private investigators were poking around, and every single thing you touched will be worth nothing.” She held my eye. “I have seen a good case die of that. Do it properly. Talk to the families, not the police. And Adonis — when you are up there, you are nobody. You have no authority whatsoever. I cannot help you. If something happens to you I will find out about it from the news.”

“Yes, Colonel.”

“Say it back.”

“We’re nobody.”

“You’re nobody,” she said.

Here is why we had to go, and it is not because of the fuel card.

The grapes on the Orange River come in before the Cape grapes do. That is not a coincidence of climate, it is the whole basis of the industry up there — a hot river valley that ripens weeks ahead, so the crews go north for that season and come south again for ours.

Which means that the six-to-nine days when the Cape has no work is *exactly* the six-to-nine days when there is movement north — and, coming the other way, that a woman who leaves a Cape valley in the shoulder and does not arrive anywhere has, as her most ordinary and most believable explanation, the sentence: *sy's Oranjerivier toe*.

She's gone to the river.

And here is what I did not understand about the river until I stood in it, and what I had entirely backwards on the drive up.

I thought: a border town, a labour camp, a lawless place where anybody can disappear.

It is not that. It is a settlement of about five thousand people on the bank of the Orange River that becomes, for nine weeks from the beginning of November, a town of twenty thousand — and the fifteen thousand who arrive do not come from our side. They come down from the north of Namibia, a thousand kilometres and more, for the early grapes, and in the second week of January they go home again and the place shrinks back to five thousand and the reed houses stand empty.

So a woman from Rawsonville who goes up there is not vanishing into chaos. She is arriving into a place where she is the foreigner, where not one person knows her face, where everybody around her is also from somewhere else and also leaving in January, and where the only census that has ever been taken is of the town that exists in the off-season.

There is no province. There is no docket. There is no country, in the sense that matters — because she is South African and she is in Namibia, and the state that might look for her has no standing there, and the state that is there has no reason to know she was ever a person who came.

She is not hidden. She is simply not in anybody's arithmetic.

I heard Elsie Mtimkulu's voice saying it while I was looking at that river, and I had to go and sit in the car.

Piet said it in one line at the kitchen table at my house at eleven at night while my daughter was asleep upstairs.

“The window is a place,” he said. “I had it wrong. It is not only when nobody expects to hear from her. It is where nobody’s records are.”

I found four missing-persons appeals on Namibian community Facebook pages in two evenings. Four. Two of them had South African names.

Piet found nine more in one night, because of course he did, and two of the nine were on a page for a farm settlement on the river where the population in season is in the tens of thousands and out of season is not.

We did not know what any of them meant. We still don’t know what most of them meant. I want that in, because when the number went public later, it went public as a number, and numbers do not carry the words *we do not know what most of these mean*, and I have spent two years trying to put those words back on.

I told Aunty Miems on the Friday.

“Ons gaan op,” I said. “Noordkaap toe, en dan miskien oor die grens.”

She was quiet.

“Aunty?”

“Hoe lank?”

“I don’t know. Weeks.”

“En sal jy nog Vrydae bel?”

And I said yes, and I meant it, and I did — from Springbok, from Kakamas, from a filling station at Vioolsdrif with the wind taking the door out of my hand, from a room in Keetmanshoop with the phone held up against the window for signal. Every Friday. Eleven of them.

Except one, and I will get to it.

We left on the Monday.

Riaan came out to the pavement in his apron and gave Piet a bicycle pump, which I did not understand and did not ask about, and Piet put it in the boot without comment, and it is still in the boot of that car today.

I drove first. Out through Malmesbury and up the N7 with the sun coming over on the right, past the wheat and then out of the wheat, and by Piketberg the country had started doing the thing it does, which is get bigger and emptier and older, and by Clanwilliam neither of us had spoken for an hour and it was the good kind.

Somewhere past Vanrhynsdorp Piet said, "Adonis."

"Ja."

"If I become certain," he said, "will you tell me."

I took my eyes off the road for a second to look at him, and he was looking straight ahead with his hands on his knees.

"Ja, Piet," I said. "I'll tell you."

I want that on the record too. He asked. Out of his own mouth, unprompted, four hundred kilometres before it mattered, he asked me to do exactly the thing I then did not do.

Afterword — What Is Real

This is a novel. Piet Buys never existed, and neither did the man he hunts. The country they move through does.

I want to be precise about the line between those two things, because a crime novel that blurs it is doing something dishonest to people who are still alive.

The women

Deline Fortuin, Bernadine Klaasen, Neliswa Mgcini, Amoret Booysen, Sylvia Tafira, Rochelle, Mmapula — every woman in this book is invented. So is every mother. Auntie Miems Fortuin is not anyone.

The reason nobody looked for them is not invented.

The killers I did not use

There are real South African serial-murder cases in the record, and their offenders are alive and in prison, and their victims are survived by mothers and sisters in Gauteng and the Cape right now. I have not named any of them in the story and I have not put invented acts on a real person's name. Naming them would have been a defamation exposure; more to the point, it would have handed those men another book, and they have enough.

What I took from the record was **method**, and only method:

- **The fake job offer.** In a Gauteng series in 1994–95, the offender ran a shell organisation posing as an anti-abuse charity, walked through townships handing out official-looking

forms, and offered women desk jobs that did not exist. He was convicted of 38 murders and 40 rapes. That is the most South African predation there is — the weaponising of unemployment — and it is the seed of this book's central mechanism. I changed the crucial thing: in *The Unnumbered*, **the work is real**. The farm exists, the wage exists, the crew exists. Only the destination is false, and only sometimes. Invent a farm and eventually somebody phones it. Nobody ever phones a real farm to ask whether a woman who was on nobody's list arrived somewhere she was never officially going.

- **The transport corridor.** Between 2005 and 2007 at least five women were murdered in Namibia, their remains found near the national road that runs the length of that country. Three were identified; two never were. One man was arrested and acquitted for lack of evidence; another was implicated after his suicide in 2008. **The case remains unsolved.** I took the shape of an unsolved series running across a border that no single police service owns. I did not take the offender's signature, and I did not solve his case in fiction, because it is not mine to solve.

The investigators

Piet Buys is not a portrait of a real person. He owes his patience and his method of building a case slowly, from paper and from confidence, to **Piet Byleveld**, the South African detective who died in 2017 after thirty-eight years, and who worked the cases the previous section describes obliquely. He owes his *profession* to **Dr Micki Pistorius**, who founded the SAPS Investigative Psychology Unit in 1996 and was this country's first profiler, and to **Dr Gérard Labuschagne**, who ran that unit for some fourteen and a half years after her.

None of the three is in this book. Byleveld was a detective, not a profiler, and worked in Gauteng, not the Cape. Their work is the reason it was possible to imagine a man like Buys at all.

The country

These are the load-bearing facts. Every one is sourced. Where I could not source a number, I have not given one — which is Elsie Mtimkulu's rule in chapter eleven, and it is mine.

Safety is a purchased commodity. More than 2.6 million security officers are registered with PSIRA, of whom roughly 586,000 are actively employed. The South African Police Service had a personnel strength of 184,106 as at 31 March 2024. South Africa has the largest private security industry per capita in the world — more active private officers than the police service and the defence force combined. Nothing about Hendrik Buys's company is exaggerated for effect.

There is no twenty-four-hour rule. There never was. SAPS is explicit that a missing-person report must be opened and investigated immediately, that the SAPS 55(A) is completed with the complainant present, and that details go onto the National Bureau for Missing Persons system. The Portfolio Committee on Police has had to issue a public statement about stations not adhering to that directive. Auntie Miems was turned away three times in this novel, and every one of those refusals was against standing instruction, and nobody broke a law, and nobody would be disciplined. That is the quietest and most devastating fact I found while writing this.

The FCS units — Family Violence, Child Protection and Sexual Offences — were broken up in late September 2006 and re-established in June 2010. Charmaine Adonis's career is built exactly on that gap, because thousands of real detectives' careers were.

The unidentified dead. As at August 2024 there were roughly 3,186 unclaimed bodies in state mortuaries nationally, some held for as long as six years. In 2024 the Western Cape conducted 289 pauper burials, 279 of them in the Cape Town metro. A body may be released for pauper burial after thirty days. The national forensic DNA backlog has exceeded 140,000 cases. And the National Forensic DNA Database supports **familial searching** — the technique that could match a mother's swab to an unidentified daughter — but that capability is not aimed at the missing. It is legislated and resourced for crime, and it works at that. There is no standing programme that takes swabs from the families of missing persons and runs them

against the unidentified dead.

Elsie Mtimkulu's argument in chapter eleven is the argument of this whole book. They are not nameless and they are not un-numbered — every one of them has a case number, a DR number, a plot number, a page in a book. They are simply never **counted**. There is no total anywhere that anyone has to stand up and answer for, because nobody was ever given the job of adding them up.

That is the title.

The labour system. In 2012, of roughly 121,000 farm workers in the Western Cape, slightly more than half were seasonal — mostly women — and employed through labour brokers. The industry has moved steadily away from permanent on-farm workers toward off-farm seasonal and casual workers on short-term contracts or none. Table grapes in the Cape run from vine preparation in August and September through to packing in March and April. From 1 March 2026 the national minimum wage, including for farm workers, is R30.23 an hour.

On the Orange River, at Aussenkehr in Namibia's Karas Region — immediately across the border — the grapes ripen earlier, harvested from early November to the second week of January. A settlement of around five thousand people becomes as many as twenty thousand for those nine weeks, and the seasonal workforce comes down from the north of Namibia, a thousand kilometres and more. The living conditions there have been documented repeatedly and critically by Namibian and South African journalists.

And there is no filling station at Vioolsdrif. The last diesel in the Republic is at Steinkopf, sixty-seven kilometres short of the bridge. The next pump is at Noordoewer, on the other side, where the N7 stops being the N7.

De Doorns, November 2009. Between the 14th and the 17th, xenophobic violence in De Doorns displaced around three thousand Zimbabwean farm workers — sixty-eight in the first wave at Ekuphumleni, roughly three thousand in the second — who sheltered first at the police station and then on the Hexvallei sports field. It was the only *rural* site of violence in the national wave of 2008 and 2009. A character in this book refers to it once, in passing, the way you refer to a year rather than an event, and the book does not dramatise it, and

that restraint is deliberate.

I will say plainly here what the novel refuses to say on the page: that violence came out of people competing for six-week jobs inside a system built to make them compete. The machine is the villain of this book. It is never the people.

What is still owed

This draft has outstanding verification of its own, and I would rather print the list than pretend there isn't one: whether a labour broker is legally obliged to retain a crew list, and for how long; the real timeline of a mutual legal assistance request between South Africa and Namibia; whether a South African fleet card transacts across that border and who a monthly debit would fall on; how Namibia handles a missing-person report for a foreign national made by a foreign family; and what a chain of custody held by a private company is actually worth in a South African court. If the answer to that last one is *nothing*, the scene will change, and it will be a better scene.

Corrections are welcome and will be used.

— A.J.G., July 2026



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor